

ADVENTIST REVIEW

OCTOBER 2024: OUR MISSION: URGENT! +
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TRENDING

THE MOST SHARED
STORIES ON
ADVENTISTREVIEW.ORG
LAST MONTH:

1



Pescovegetarian Diets Best for Reducing Risk of Death in Elderly, Study Says, by Ansel Oliver, Loma Linda University Health

2



Adventist College Alumnus Ranks Second Nationwide in Licensure Examination, by Mennen Pearl Caballero and *Adventist Review*

3



A Miracle in Waiting, by Sorin Petrof with Trans-European Division

4



America's Prophet, by Clifford Goldstein

5



Changing of the Guard, by Merle Poirier



The Wants of the Cause of Christ

This editorial appeared in the Review, July 6, 1869. It seemed appropriate to publish these words again as we celebrate and remember John Nevins Andrews, the Adventist Church's first missionary. Andrews accepted that call in 1874. In 1869 he served as editor of the Review. The length has been adjusted because of limited space, but the full text in its original format may be read by going to Adventist Archives online.—Justin Kim.



The cause of Christ suffers for the lack of faithful, devoted men. It is not great men that are the strength of the cause of truth, but men of piety and experience, who live not for themselves, but for Him that died for them and rose again. This class is the strength of the church, for they make God their strength and their dependence. It is not rich men that are demanded. . . . It is not men of great minds, but men of great hearts, that God is pleased to accept. Great talents and abundant wealth might be rendered of inestimable service in the cause of Christ. But for the most

part, Satan is able to enlist all this in his own service.

The cause of Christ, however, is not dependent upon men. He who stands at the head of the work can use the feeblest instrumentality for the advancement of His cause. He invites all to become His servants. He chooses, out of all this vast number thus invited, those only who render submission to His service. . . . He has no place for the self-conceited, boastful man. Nor is there any place to be filled by the self-righteous, unhumiliated Pharisee. The Saviour has no use for those who are only able, like Peter in the garden, to fight for Him, but are quite unable to suffer shame for His sake. There are plenty of those who have zeal for self and for their own advancement, who have no interest for Christ that ever manifests itself in acts of devotion to His cause. The Lord has no use for any of these persons. . . .

1. The cause of God needs the service of soundly converted men. These are the persons who have put off the old man and put on the new. Self, in them, has died. Rather, it dies daily. To them the cause of God is dearer than life. . . . These are, indeed, the people of God. These are the persons who walk with God. . . .

No matter how lowly their station, or how humble their gift, and their calling, they are the pillars of the church. If all who connect themselves with the cause of God were of this class the work of God would make steady, onward progress.

2. The cause of God needs men who count not their own lives dear unto themselves.

There are but few such men in the world; but wherever they are found they are the servants of Christ. They never strive for the pre-eminence, except in that which makes no display. The church is never burdened with trials which these men cause. The men of the world are never stumbled by their evil example. They let their light so shine that others see their good works and glorify their Father in heaven.

3. The cause of God needs men that can bear disappointment.

The record of God's people shows that they have been subjected, at certain times, to this trial. Indeed, it appears that it has been the portion of those most eminent in His service. Moses, Elijah, John the Baptist, and the apostles of Christ are all striking examples of this fact. God suffers His servants to be subjected to bitter disappointment to show what is in their hearts. . . . Disappointment shows whether

It demands faithfulness, zeal, self-sacrifice, humility, and every Christian grace in the heart and life of those who are recognized as the ministers of Jesus Christ.

the heart is really steadfast with God, and it seems to be the lot of all the people of God to meet it in their experience.

4. The cause of God needs humble, patient, watchful, exemplary men, who love and fear the Creator of the heavens and the earth. It needs genuine Christians. It needs those whose whole souls are in the work. It needs those who have the honor of God and the salvation of men nearer their hearts than they have any other object. It suffers because those who have named the name of Christ have not departed from all iniquity.

5. It demands faithfulness, zeal, self-sacrifice, humility, and every Christian grace in the heart and life of those who are recognized as the ministers of Jesus Christ. With such a ministry how would the Lord go forth to the battle, and what a church would we have to illustrate their preaching. The servants of the living God would be indeed the valiant soldiers of Jesus Christ. And with a people every one of whom is a living Christian, what an army would we have to give battle to the powers of darkness.

6. A church soundly converted to God, . . . every member of which is an example to the flock, and with them the mighty power of the Holy Spirit

to set home the truth of God upon the people, these are the things which meet the demand of the cause of God. . . .

And now why should not this state of things exactly represent our case? Why should we not have such a ministry? . . . Why not have such members of our churches? This is the only kind that will ever enter the kingdom of God. Why should we deceive our own hearts with an empty profession? Could we have such men to preach the truth, and such men to live it out, how would the Spirit of God set home the truths of His Word. The number of churches would be multiplied, and a host of faithful men would arise to labor in the harvest field. The cause of God would prosper everywhere, and the Lord would add daily to the church such as should be saved. The people of God would be as terrible as an army with banners, and they would go forward from conquering to conquer. . . . Shall we not each one set about the work? . . .

Come, brethren, let us earnestly seek God. The hours of our probation are swiftly passing. The judgment hastens with fearful rapidity. The work committed to our trust languishes. Shall the Master come and find us thus? . . . Where is our zeal for

perishing souls? . . . Where are the acts of self-denial and cross-bearing on our part to save our perishing fellow men? How many are like the fig tree, covered with leaves, but destitute of fruit? . . . How stands our account for the great day? . . . How many of us in our own consciences can say that we are doing the will of God with earnest, persevering effort? How many love the cause of Christ above everything that they possess? The day is hastening greatly that shall reveal things as they really are. Let us prepare to meet it. 🌿

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AN ANSWER LIVED OUT

I say a hearty “Amen” to Charles Scriven’s excellent, soul-searching “What Now?” question (August 2024). I am finding, firsthand, there are a few pluses in reaching age 93. I knew Charles when he was “Chuck,” and a rather “lively PK” as well. As a former local youth leader and still very active lay minister, I’ve been privileged to rub shoulders with many young people who are now serving our Lord in many differing capacities. They are, by their lives, living the godly answer to “What Now?” Thank God for the “Chucks” and “Chuckettes”!

Kenny Campbell



EXTREMELY RELATABLE

Shawn Brace’s Reimagining Faith column titled “When the Youth Exodus Is a Good Thing” was extremely relatable and impactful (August 2024). Oh, how I love my church. And pray that my church is ready for the thousands upon thousands who are waiting for her to get her act right and collectively humble ourselves before the Lord in righteousness and love.

Libny Dubreuze (via Instagram)

A PERSONAL APPLICATION

The testimony by Connor Campbell (a pseudonym) in “The Same Today” (July 2024) is powerful. We all must take this to

heart. What does it mean to you (to me) to sacrifice for the cause of God’s mission to the earth, that people everywhere may hear the good news, the everlasting gospel of Jesus Christ (John 3:14-17; John 14:1-3; Revelation 14:6-13)?

Dean C. Read (via Facebook)

TIME TO LOOK UP

The Word of God speaks life to a broken heart: thus, mending it. As the House Call article (“Don’t Divorce Devotions,” by Peter N. Landless and Zeno L. Charles-Marcel) in the August 2024 issue advises, when circumstances crush the heart, it’s time to look up.

Robert Onsare (via Facebook)

AN APT REMINDER

I loved this reminder (in “Not Homeless. Homebound!” by Cloreth S. Greene [August 2024]) that God will take care of us! Praise God for His mercies.

Charlyne Cox (via Facebook)

MEMORY LANE

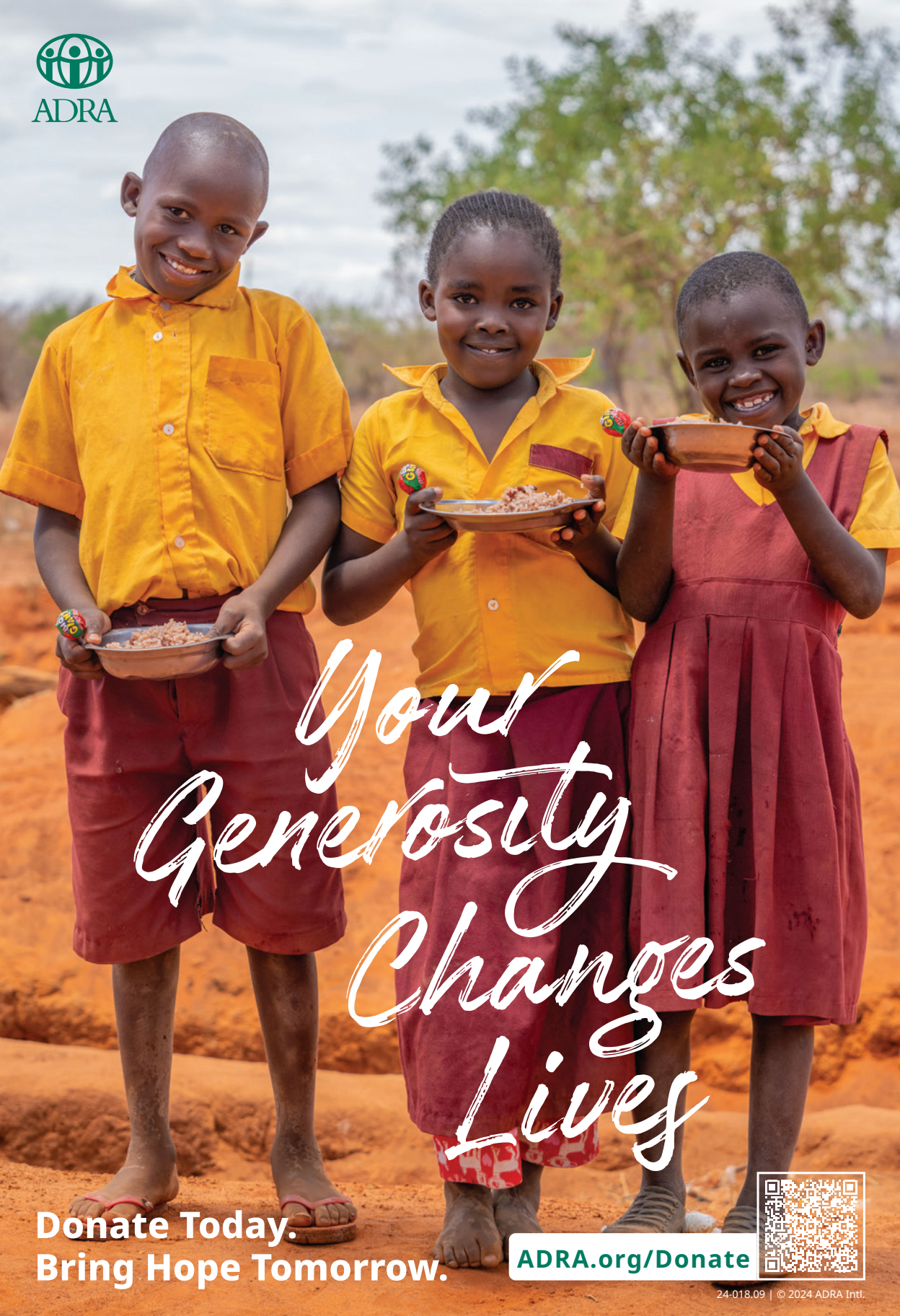
I must take this opportunity to thank Merle Poirier and the staff for the superb job you all accomplished in the recent anniversary project (July 2024). “The Glory Days” was an enjoyable walk down memory lane!

Jean Sequeira

Jean Sequeira worked as an editorial secretary for the Review from 1994 to 2002. We regret not including her, but didn’t know where to find her. We’re grateful she responded and are happy to include her comment here. One additional correction to “The Glory Days” was the name of Myrna Tetz, former managing editor.—Editors.

It was great to see pictures of the Review teams in “The Glory Days” (July 2024)! My husband, Ron, and I have subscribed to the Review for 58 years of our lives together! Before that, our parents always had it in our homes! Glad to celebrate 175 years!

Sharon Follett



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“The church really does have a voice in parliament; politicians really do listen to people of faith, especially when we show up for others.”

Moe Stiles, p. 13

NEWS



Pathfinders completing the carpentry honor created boxes for people in need to grow personal gardens.

PHOTO: COLIN GLENN, NORTH AMERICAN DIVISION

ADVENTIST COMMUNITY SERVICES COORDINATES HYGIENE KIT, GROW BOX PROJECTS

THE OFFICE SUPPORTED PROJECTS AT THE INTERNATIONAL PATHFINDER CAMPOREE.

JOHN SIMON, NORTH AMERICAN DIVISION NEWS

Helping others was a nonnegotiable dimension of the 2024 International Pathfinder Camporee, and Adventist Community Services (ACS) buttressed many of the philanthropic projects already in motion in Gillette, Wyoming.

Two particular ACS projects were somewhat attached at the hip, though they might not seem related: hygiene kits and grow boxes. Bo Gendke, ACS director for the Texas Conference and Southwestern Union

Conference, offered valuable insights, focusing primarily on the hygiene kits.

“We have several organizations that work with homeless [shelters] or shelters for youth. We decided to have the Pathfinders help us make these hygiene kits: shampoo, body wash, toothbrushes, toothpaste, a comb, a razor, some shaving cream, and a towel,” Gendke said. “Some of them don’t use all the products, but we’re try-

ing to ensure we can cover everybody there.”

Pathfinders proved throughout the week of the camporee (August 6-9), and for many prior decades, that they have a genuine heart for serving those in need. There was also interest in achieving specific honors associated with various community service efforts. “[The] serving others honor through ACS is one of [them],” Gendke said, “and the other honor is the carpentry



At the camporee, Adventist Community Services projects linked with honors attracted several Pathfinders interested in practical activities. PHOTO: COLIN GLENN, NORTH AMERICAN DIVISION

honor that [the grow box participants are] working on.”

According to Gendke, discussions for both ideas ran parallel and began last summer. On the carpentry side, “we were initially going to do tiny houses, but trying to find where we could give them out in the community was a little more difficult,” he said, “so the aboveground gardens turned out to be a better project that we could do to assist the community. We’ve been having conversations monthly for probably a year on how [and] what we would do.”

The team set a lofty goal of 7,000 hygiene kits, many of which will stay local. “We have about 3,000, I believe, that will stay in Gillette, and then the rest of them are going to specific conferences that have requested them for different ministries,” Gendke said. At the time of the interview, they were already close to the 7,000 mark, which is remarkable, considering the delays caused by the severe storm a few nights before.

STRONG SUPPORT

Gendke indicated that Cathy Kissner, ACS director for the Rocky Mountain Conference and Mid-America Union Conference, was a significant contributor to these joint endeavors; so was Walter Harris, ACS director for the Greater New York Conference. Harris offered more details about the grow boxes. He mentioned his working partnership with W. Derrick Lea, ACS director for the North American Division, which sponsored both the agricultural outreach and the hygiene kits.

Harris said discussions began approximately six months ago. “In talking with one of our partners in disaster response here in the area, the Salvation Army, they said they had a project they wanted done but didn’t have the manpower or financing to make that happen. So we jumped right on it.”

The grow boxes are enclosed wooden structures where people can establish personal gardens. This opens the door for people, primarily seniors, to set their feet

on the path to self-sustenance, especially as food affordability becomes increasingly difficult.

The box portion is four feet by two feet by two feet; it also has four one-foot legs, so it stands three feet tall, which is ergonomically friendly to most users. According to Harris, these dimensions and other details were fine-tuned to stay within the parameters of available financial and other resources.

Similar to Gendke, Harris highlighted the involvement of Pathfinder youths and their eagerness to not only assist those in need but also learn a skill as valuable as carpentry. With the complexity of construction and brevity of time, the established goal was 25 units, all of them to be distributed within the Gillette community. 🍀



The team of cyclists celebrate reaching Eugowra. PHOTO: ADVENTIST RECORD

CYCLISTS RETURN TO EUGOWRA, AUSTRALIA, TO CELEBRATE 120 YEARS OF HISTORIC EVENT

INITIATIVE HONORS THE MEMORY OF ADVENTIST PIONEER PHILIP REEKIE.

ROB HANSFORD, ADVENTIST RECORD

Inspired by Philip Reekie, a group of cyclists and their support crew embarked on a 721-mile journey from Brisbane, Queensland, to Eugowra, New South Wales, both in Australia, over seven days, riding up to 124 miles each day except for Saturday. Stopping to talk with people along the way, they shared the story of cyclist Reekie and gave out copies of Ellen G. White's *The Great Controversy* and the guidebook *Your Bible and You*. As a result, hundreds of books were distributed in the communities that they cycled through.

"People are just so receptive to a chat and receiving all that we had to give them," the riders shared at a visit with the Narrabri, Dubbo, and Narromine churches in Narrabri. "Don't be afraid to use every opportunity to connect with people and share Adventist literature." They concluded their ride at the old Eugowra Adventist church, welcomed by family and friends.

Philip Ainslie Reekie, born in Scotland in 1846, immigrated to Australia in 1888 after being widowed and divorced. In 1889 he encountered an Adventist book, discovering Bible truths and leading to a personal encounter with Jesus.

He had found not only a new country but also a reason to live.

Wanting to share his newfound hope, he left his work as an engraver to etch God's Word upon the hearts of others. On dusty roads throughout regional Australia, Reekie rode a bicycle many miles, distributing Adventist literature.

One of the properties Reekie visited near Eugowra belonged to Tom Kent. Kent had recently lost his wife, Mary, to pneumonia. She had made him promise that he would ensure he and their 11 children would meet her in heaven. Kent had no idea how to keep that promise until his encounter with Reekie, who shared *The Great Controversy* with him. After studying the book, Kent accepted its teachings, was baptized, and shared his new faith with family and neighbors, leading five of the neighboring families to baptism.

These six families—Chatman, Gersbach, Grey, Kent, Packham, and Thompson—built a small mud-brick church, which was dedicated in June 1904. It was the first Seventh-day Adventist church west of the Blue Mountains and the first in the current South New South Wales Conference. To com-

memorate 120 years since its dedication, more than 130 descendants and friends of the pioneering families gathered in Eugowra on June 1 to celebrate.

Andrew Kingston led out opening Sabbath, recalling stories from his grandfather, the youngest of Tom and Mary Kent's children. Sabbath was opened with Psalm 23, a tradition of the Eugowra families.

On Sabbath Anthony Kent, associate Ministerial secretary of the General Conference, spoke about the pioneering families' passion for mission work and their significant impact. There have been 17 ministers among their descendants who have contributed to tens of thousands becoming Seventh-day Adventists through church plants and evangelism.

On Sabbath afternoon attendees gathered at the old Eugowra church, where Calvin Drinkall, South New South Wales Conference general secretary, discussed the Eugowra church's significance to the Adventist Church in Australia.

Gary Kent reminded those present that the Eugowra church was built as a memorial of Bible truths. "Those families chose to make a stand for their newfound beliefs," he said. ▀

Members of the GC Secretariat team and local church leaders smile after completing the binding of *Mission* quarterlies at the Cuba Union Conference printshop. PHOTO: ASHTON WEISS, MARANATHA VOLUNTEERS INTERNATIONAL



GC SECRETARIAT TEAM PARTNERS TO SUPPORT CUBA'S PRINTSHOP, SEMINARY

COLLABORATION WITH MARANATHA RESULTS IN IMPROVEMENTS FOR MEMBERS AND STUDENTS.

MARCOS PASEGGI, ADVENTIST REVIEW

A novel collaboration between a team from the Seventh-day Adventist Church's General Conference (GC) Secretariat and the nonprofit supporting ministry Maranatha Volunteers International resulted in tangible improvements for church members and leaders in Cuba.

On a mission trip to Cuba, employees from the Adventist Church headquarters in Silver Spring, Maryland, led evangelistic meetings in churches across Havana; helped paint and repair a church building; and met with regional church leaders to discuss ways of increasing their support. The GC Secretariat team also visited the Cuba Adventist Theological Seminary on the outskirts of Havana and the printshop on its campus.

Maranatha arrived in Cuba in the 1990s to support church construction and remodeling initiatives. Since then it has returned to Cuba for more than 200 projects, including the construction of most of the buildings at the seminary, including a church building.

After the COVID-19 pandemic, Maranatha has been supporting the school by shipping donor-funded containers with food to help church members and the seminary. All these initiatives have been instrumental in keeping the school open.

PRESSING NEEDS

On July 30 the GC Secretariat team visited the seminary's campus and the printshop, where, with painstaking effort, a team of church workers prints Adventist literature to be distributed across the country.

When the GC Secretariat team and Maranatha leaders met earlier in 2024 to plan for the outreach initiative, they agreed that besides the food to be provided by Maranatha, the printshop was in dire need of supplies, including paper and ink.

"In the past there were times that printing ink was not available, and the printshop had to resort to using motor oil to reprint their quarterlies and other Adventist publications," an employee at the printshop said. Those who serve at the printshop have learned to make the most of what they have on hand. Scraps of paper are usually transformed to become tithe and offering envelopes. Thanks to the support of the GC Secretariat team, the printshop has received enough paper to print church materials for the next couple of quarters.

The visit allowed the GC Secretariat team to take a hands-on approach to one of the services provided by the printshop. Team members participated in the manual binding process of the *Mission* quar-

terlies in Spanish for the fourth quarter of 2024. There they had a close-up view of the effort involved, as the binding process, including stacking up the pages in the correct order and stapling them, is fully manual.

ONGOING ASSISTANCE

The printshop has other needs too. "The presses are really old, and one of the newest ones is a German press from the early 1950s," a printshop employee said. "We make them keep working, but when they break because of wear and tear or for any other reason, it is almost impossible to get the repair parts needed."

The Cuba Adventist Theological Seminary also needs ongoing support. "Currently we are expecting around 40 first-year theology students, and one in three of them are women," regional church leaders said. They stressed the urgency of training new leaders and replacing the ministers who have left. "The role of the seminary is essential for the long-term success of the Adventist Church in Cuba," they said. "We are thankful for this partnership." 📌

ADRA representative Selba-Gondoza Luka (center) and Moe Stiles (third from right) met with Australia's minister for Foreign Affairs Penny Wong (third from left) and minister for International Development and the Pacific Pat Conroy (center) on August 14.

PHOTO: ADVENTIST RECORD



ADVENTIST WOMEN JOIN CHRISTIAN LEADERS LOBBYING FOR AID INCREASES IN AUSTRALIA

“THE CHURCH REALLY HAS A VOICE IN PARLIAMENT,” AN ADVENTIST LEADER SAID.

NATHAN BROWN, ADVENTIST RECORD

Four women representing the Adventist Development and Relief Agency (ADRA) in Victoria, Australia, joined other Christian leaders to ask national political leaders to increase their commitment to Australian aid.

ADRA Victoria director Rebecca Auriant, Selba-Gondoza Luka, Kate Pincheira, and Moe Stiles were among 35 Christian leaders from across Australia who met in Canberra at this year's Women's Leaders Network event, hosted by Micah Australia. On August 14 Micah groups met with 42 elected representatives at Parliament House, along with relevant government ministers and shadow ministers.

In asking Australia's political leaders to increase Australian aid from its historically low current levels to 1 percent of the national budget, Micah Australia's message was that “as churches, organizations, and communities, we care deeply about the level of aid Australia provides.” Both Auriant and Luka were able to share their firsthand experiences of the benefits of Australian aid, with Auriant having worked with ADRA in Nepal and Luka working with African diaspora communities in southeastern Melbourne, including students from Malawi who have benefited from university education in Australia

and then been able to return to their home country to serve their own people.

“When I spent time in Nepal, I witnessed how Australian aid through ADRA increased livelihood, health, and educational opportunities for families,” Auriant said. “As a Seventh-day Adventist Christian, when I hear that 700 million of my brothers and sisters around the world are still living in extreme poverty and one in five children are in conflict zones, I must do something about it—and speaking with our political leaders is a way to do that.”

Pincheira is an art teacher at Nunawading Christian College and volunteers regularly with ADRA in Melbourne. As part of the Women's Leaders Network worship program, she created a live work of art—which will be displayed in Micah Australia's office in Newcastle—but she also reflected on what she learned from speaking up with Micah. “Micah has earned the respect of parliamentarians, and the politicians we met with were welcoming to us, were willing to listen and to engage in discussion, and treated us respectfully,” she said. “I learned the power of meeting politicians in person; being in front of each other is disarming—and the Micah team demonstrated the high value of compelling re-

search, supporting and trusting your team, and showing up in a professional manner.”

Having participated in Micah's Women's Leaders Network a number of times, Moe Stiles, pastor of Crosswalk Melbourne, reflected on the strength and potential of “the collective voice of faith.”

“The church really does have a voice in parliament; politicians really do listen to people of faith,” she said. “Especially when we show up for others, and not just for our own rights and freedoms. Consistency matters—advocating for others matters.”

The messages delivered by the Women's Leaders Network to political leaders are part of Micah Australia's “A Safer World for All” campaign. Micah Australia is a coalition of Christian development and justice agencies, of which ADRA Australia is a partner. According to its website, the organization empowers Australian Christians to advocate on the most urgent global justice issues facing our world today—extreme poverty, rising conflict, and climate change. “Through our key initiatives and campaigns, we support Australian Christians and church leaders to engage our federal politicians warmly and relationally, leading to significant outcomes on key issues of global justice,” the organization said. ▀

Scene from the daily allusion to the biblical story of Joseph and his brothers. PHOTO: © APD/TL



HOPE CAMP IN GERMANY INSPIRES ADVENTIST FAMILIES AND FRIENDS

“CREATE LEISURE TIME, MAKE FRIENDS, DISCOVER FAITH” WAS THE EVENT’S MOTTO.

MAGDALENA LACHMANN, HOPE MEDIA EUROPE, AND ADVENTIST REVIEW

It’s like a little piece of paradise that we’re experiencing here with our children. The friendly community and togetherness, and the fact that my children can move around so freely . . . that’s something you can take into everyday life and try to pass on,” said a visibly content young mother near the end of Hope Camp.

The young mother is one of nearly 600 participants who were drawn to the area near Magdeburg this year to experience one of the largest Christian family camps in Germany. Organized for the fourth time by the Seventh-day Adventist Church in Germany and Hope Media Europe in Alsbach-Hähnlein, this year’s event once again adopted the motto “Create Leisure Time, Make Friends, Discover Faith.”

FUN AND GAMES ON THE RUNNING MEADOW

From July 30 to August 4 the campus of Friedensau Theological Seminary was transformed into a “Wuselwiese” (German for “running meadow”). This new feature is especially aimed at families with children between 0 and 7 years old.

Since attention spans are shorter and the urge to move is high in this age group, the large meadow on the campus offered a mix of activities, such as a

bouncy castle, a baby play area, a water play pool, a rolling slide, a mini soccer field, and other age-appropriate creative crafting and play options. But even in the other “experience worlds,” there was a vibrant program for children, teenagers, adults, singles, and seniors.

“When children are busy all day, making friends, having fun, and hearing about God, parents are relaxed and happy too,” Hope Camp leader Alexander Kampmann said. “The idea of this event is for generations to come together, like at a big family celebration, to enjoy a holiday together and invite friends. I personally enjoy sitting under string lights in the evening, with a hot dog in hand and a view of our glamping tent landscape, talking about God and the world while the children have fun on the wooden carousel. For me, it’s a little taste of heaven.”

According to organizers, of the almost 600 who registered, about 200 were under 15 years old, while the oldest participant was a proud 93 years old. Eighty-one volunteers supported the organizing team and significantly contributed to the event’s success, organizers said.

REACHING THE HEART

Participants enjoyed discussing spiritual topics, among other things, through a daily spiritual message from Klaus Popa in the arena. He is not only the chair of Hope Media but also the host of the Hope TV series “glauben.geschichten” (believe.stories).

In Popa’s messages and the accompanying biblical plays, which included music, everything revolved around the Old Testament story of Jacob’s favorite son, Joseph. Joseph’s story is a reminder that through God’s mercy and goodness, reconciliation is possible, Popa said. It also shows how a heart ready to forgive can pave the way for healing and reunion.

Another emotional highlight of the Hope Camp vacation week was the baptism of four participants, which took place on Saturday afternoon in the lake nearby. The candidates decided on this day to entrust their lives to Jesus. During the subsequent prayer, other people stepped forward, wanting to follow this example. The baptisms were also a decision for a life “with depth,” as Alexander Kampmann described in his address. He referred to Acts 17:10, 11, where people searched deeper in the Holy Scriptures to discover the “more in life.”

A volunteer wears a T-shirt with the slogan “Reaching the Unreached,” as the new batch of volunteers prepares to embark on their mission. PHOTO: ZPM COMMUNICATION DEPARTMENT



FIVE NEW SCHOOLS AND VOLUNTEERS BRING HOPE TO WAR-STRICKEN AREA

IN SOUTHERN PHILIPPINES, ADVENTIST TEAMS HOPE TO EDUCATE AND TRAIN.

LESLEY JOY ESTRELLA, ZAMBOANGA PENINSULA MISSION, SOUTHERN ASIA-PACIFIC DIVISION

On July 24, during a courtesy call to the Seventh-day Adventist Church in the Zamboanga Peninsula Mission (ZPM) in Tiayon, Ipil, church leaders announced 60 new volunteers and the establishment of five additional schools in the war-stricken areas of Sulu and Tawi-Tawi in the Philippines. This collaborative effort between ZPM, the Socio-Economic Uplift, Literacy, Anthropological, and Developmental Services (SULADS), and the Adventist Muslim Relations (AMR) initiative aims to bring education and hope to these regions, assisting in their steady recovery from the ravages of conflict.

IN THE SULU CLUSTER

In the Sulu Cluster there are two sites: Sulari and Kahoy Sinah, both located in Parang, Sulu. This island, situated in the southern Philippines, is rich in culture, has abundant marine resources, and is home to the Tausug and Badjao tribes, among the most solid Muslim tribes in the country. In November 2022 the Special Forces declared Sulu terrorist-free despite having experienced more than two decades of war.

For the longest time Sulu lacked peace, education, and livelihood, especially in remote areas. However, the situation is improving. Two flourishing schools, the Peace Formation and Learning Centers, are located in Bud Bunga and Upper Sinumaan,

Talipao, Sulu, serving the Tausug people. Last school year (2023-2024) these schools accommodated 328 students, excluding adult classes, according to registrar Fella Paga-pong. With their new supervisor, Junarey Duarte, and the support of new volunteers, four schools will be in full operation starting in 2024.

The influence of ZPM, SULADS, and AMR continues to grow in Tawi-Tawi, known as the seaweed capital of the Philippines. New schools will be established on Tahao Island and Guakan Island, with the school on Tambunan Island reopening, regional church leaders said.

IN THE TAWI-TAWI REGION

The Tawi-Tawi Cluster, which includes schools on Bagid, Laa, Tando, Punduhan, Liabuoran, Tong Bankaw, and Tah-tah islands, served 800 students last school year. These students primarily belong to the Sama, Tausug, Badjao, and Jama Mapun tribes, according to Duarte, former supervisor in the Tawi-Tawi Cluster. With new leadership from cluster supervisor Diodolo Luad, 10 schools will be fully operational in 2024.

These schools have become annexes to the local education department schools, allowing students to pursue their dreams through the dedication of ZPM, SULADS, and AMR volunteers. The establishment of these

five new schools aims to extend education and hope to more communities, providing opportunities for those who seek learning, peaceful living, and a bright future.

Volunteers will engage in community activities, conduct house-to-house visitations, offer basic medical care, such as blood pressure checks, and promote healthy living. They are planning to provide free education to both adults and children and introduce basic livelihood skills to help sustain families.

The new batch of volunteers received heartfelt encouragement from church leaders, with ZPM executive secretary Vilmar Mandalupa urging them to emulate the biblical David, a man after God's own heart, and reminding them that God qualifies those He calls.

ZPM education director Victor Palin inspired volunteers to give their best efforts while keeping God at the center of their lives. Additionally, ZPM Adventist Mission director Ranny De Vera provided an orientation on the volunteers' responsibilities in the field, addressing their needs through the HEAL (Health, Education, Agriculture, and Livelihood) program of SULADS.

Leaders said that “with unwavering support from ZPM administrators and workers, this year's batch of volunteers is now ready for their mission.”

A panel of film production experts speak during the first Chiapas Mexican Union Conference film festival in Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Chiapas, Mexico.

PHOTO: CHIAPAS MEXICAN UNION CONFERENCE



FILM FESTIVAL IN MEXICO HIGHLIGHTS COMMITMENT TO SPREAD THE GOSPEL

EVENT IS PART OF A STRATEGY TO ENGAGE CREATIVE YOUNG PEOPLE IN MISSION.

YOSAINY OYAGA AND LIBNA STEVENS, INTER-AMERICAN DIVISION NEWS

The Seventh-day Adventist Church in Chiapas, Mexico, recently hosted its first film festival during a special gathering in Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Chiapas. The UMCH Short Film Festival showcased 19 short films produced by young people (referred to as Creative Disciples) engaged in fulfilling the mission, drawing more than 120 audiovisual project creators, local field leaders, communication leaders, and special guests.

“This is an evangelism celebration, a celebration of the commitment of each young person in spreading the gospel,” José Luis Bouhot, secretary of the Adventist Church’s Chiapas Mexican Union Conference, host of the event, said as the festival began.

Teams from each of the nine fields across Chiapas took it to heart to express through films, from four minutes to 30 minutes long, on the assigned theme “Jesus Is Enough,” featuring messages of faith and hope for a troubled world through stories based on real life and original stories. Showcasing of the short films began on Friday evening, July 19.

A PURPOSEFUL MINISTRY

Being seen as a purposeful film ministry is what can make a difference in the church, organizers said. “Jesus told parables to show

truths and mysteries of His kingdom, and stories through films have that objective to transmit those same truths and mysteries,” said Uriel Castellanos, communication director of the Chiapas Mexican Union and main organizer of the festival.

“Union leaders believe that the preaching of the gospel should be done in all possible platforms. That is why these spaces are made for members to put their gifts and talents in service for God,” Castellanos said. It’s all about training, collaborating, celebrating creative content, and inspiring a transforming encounter with Jesus, who is the creator, screenwriter, and director of our lives, he added.

SHARING THE GREATEST STORY

In addition to the films projected, the event included keynote presentations, talks, and a question-and-answer session on cinematography and evangelism, as well as the production teams’ experiences during filming. Young creatives were challenged to continue growing and producing Christian content that impacts people.

“This is a unique event in which we have seen an explosion of creativity and talent,” said Hellen H. Castro, director of Creativo 115, who has produced and directed many

film projects for the Adventist Church. “The initiative of this festival is a dream for us, who are dedicated to the audiovisual world, to be able to meet so many creatives,” Castro said. “In a world so saturated with images and sounds, the Chiapas Mexican Union has opened an authentic and valid space so that the emerging talents of our community can show their vision and passion to share with others the greatest story.”

The film festival was not only about showcasing films together but also part of a strategy the church has been working toward for several years, Castellanos said.

To be able to feature films during the festival, production teams had to attend online classes led by what they coined as Hope Virtual Academy—an educational initiative by the church’s Hope Media Chiapas, a media center that is part of Hope Channel Inter-America television network. The initiative saw the teams training for six months this year to learn cinematography language and techniques, Castellanos said. “They learned from Adventist producers from across Inter-America and beyond on scriptwriting, direction, production, and post-production, as well as going deep into movies as a tool for sharing the gospel,” he said. ▀



TED PASTORS GATHER FOR A DIVISION-WIDE CONFERENCE IN BELGRADE, SERBIA.

Nearly 1,200 pastors, Bible workers, departmental leaders, and accompanying spouses from across the Trans-European Division (TED) gathered August 27-31 for the fifth European Pastors' Council. The TED includes 28 countries, islands, and territories in western and central Europe. The event's program, comprised of 50 workshops and 11 plenary presentations, addressed the pressing need for intentional involvement in the challenging milieu of the TED territory.



ADVENTIST CHURCH IN SOUTHEAST ASIA ADDRESSES GLOBAL YOUTH CHALLENGES.

The Southeastern Asia Union Mission hosted its inaugural Youth Alive program in Battambang, Cambodia, July 25-27, which drew more than 100 young leaders from four countries. This program was important when considering the significant challenges faced by young people in Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, and Thailand. In these countries more than 50 percent of the population is under the age of 30, and this demographic faces a multitude of challenges.



2024 EUROPEAN CONFERENCE ON FAITH AND SCIENCE CONVENES IN LONDON.

The conference drew a group of more than 50 participants and was hosted by the Geoscience Research Institute. For four days attendees explored a wide range of topics, from the foundational role of the Bible in scientific inquiry to the challenges posed by scientism and fundamentalism. Presentations explored the tension between naturalism and deep time versus the concept of catastrophe and design and the critical question of what the God of the Bible has to do with modern science.



ADVENTIST HOSPITAL PIONEERS GOVERNMENT HEALTH INITIATIVE IN THE PHILIPPINES.

Adventist Hospital Davao (AHD) officially launched the "Konsulta" Package Program with a ribbon-cutting ceremony at the AHD Consultation Center on August 5. AHD is the first among 12 Adventist hospitals in the Philippines and the second in the Davao region to implement PhilHealth's free consultation program. The Konsulta package provides free annual checkups, selected diagnostics, and medicines for Filipino patients. The program offers various medical services, including pharmaceutical products, devices, and procedures.



YOUTH VOLUNTEERS RESTORE HISTORIC STREETS IN PERU.

More than 100 youth from the Caleb Mission initiative gathered in Cusco, Peru, to participate in cleaning and painting public spaces in the historic neighborhood of San Blas, in the capital of the old Inca Empire. The Caleb Mission Project is a voluntary social service and evangelism program that encourages Adventist youth to dedicate their vacations to reach new people. The goal is to mobilize young people in South America to evangelize where there is no Adventist presence.



JAPAN ADVENTISTS BRIDGE FAITH AND CULTURE WITH THE MANGA MISSION PROJECT.

The Publishing Department of the Japan Union Conference published in July a manga book inspired by Ellen G. White's *The Great Controversy*. This unique project represents a milestone in blending traditional religious narratives with contemporary Japanese culture. The idea is for the book to engage the younger generations by making complex theological concepts accessible and intriguing. The project conveys the meaning of Jesus' sacrifice to children, young people, and adults who may not yet know God.



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A MACEDONIAN CALL FROM SWITZERLAND

*Following
the providence
of God*

GILBERT M. VALENTINE

The apostle Paul received his call to overseas mission in a dream. A foreigner had pleaded with him, “Come over to Macedonia and help us” (Acts 16:9, NRSV). Did Paul recognize the man by his clothing? his accent? And just where in Macedonia? No place was specified, although the province wasn’t a really big place. Details were lacking. Nevertheless, Paul and his companions interpreted the dream as a call from God, and they left the next day in faith. They traveled from Asia Minor across the Aegean Sea and planted the first Christian church in Europe in the port city of Philippi. There they met an immigrant businesswoman from Paul’s home province, and she welcomed the missionaries into her home. Providence?

The Adventist Church received its call to venture into overseas mission not in a dream but in a letter written in 1869. *Review* editor John Andrews answered the letter. Further correspondence led to an invitation to “come over and help us.” Andrews himself would answer the call. This, too, was seen as a clear leading of providence.

OUT OF ASHES

Adventism’s “Macedonian call” had come from Switzerland. It was perhaps a little more complicated than Luke’s account of the one the apostle Paul had received. The Swiss letter writer represented a small group of watchmakers living in a cluster of villages in the Jura Mountains just north of Neuchâtel who had found themselves in trouble. They had heard about the seventh-day Sabbath and had begun to keep it, and had heard about the Second Advent and believed it.

Some years earlier they had responded to the preaching and teaching of a Polish former Roman Catholic priest, Michael Czechowski. He had settled in one of their villages for a short time as a Protestant missionary with sponsors in America. The Swiss Sabbathkeepers were spiritual heirs of Zwingli’s reformation, with some from a Lutheran background. Czechowski, who had earlier been converted to Adventism and was enthusiastic about the Sabbath and Advent teaching, had wanted his church to send him as a missionary to Europe, but Seventh-day Adventist leaders did

The response to this call required not only evangelistic passion and preaching skills. It also required skill in pastoral understanding and pastoral care.

not feel able to trust him. He went anyway, but sponsored by a first-day Advent church. He preached Advent teaching in various places, but along the way he also secretly taught Seventh-day Adventist doctrine, including the Sabbath, and he organized his converts into five small congregational groups. Then things went wrong.

His deception was exposed, the little religious publishing business he had established went bankrupt, and he decided to flee the area, leaving his wife and children behind. The Sabbathkeepers lost serious money. There was conflict. Then they found out that their pastor was caught up in some moral irregularities. They were badly hurt and confused.

In rummaging through Czechowski's papers, they discovered a copy of the *Review and Herald* and learned, to their astonishment, about Seventh-day Adventists. Now more confused, they wrote to the editor, John Andrews, to find out more about their Sabbathkeeping cousins. A correspondence began.

RECALIBRATING

Like Paul hearing the call of the Macedonian and being "convinced that God had called" him to Europe, so Seventh-day Adventists recognized the opening of providence in the news of the group in Switzerland. But the language barriers and the cultural differences were much more of a hurdle for Andrews than they had been for Paul when he had first ventured overseas. It took some time for the young Adventist denomination to assemble an adequate fund for the new endeavor and then further time to decide on who should be sent. Finally, five years after the first correspondence, they authorized the answering of their "Macedonian" call in August 1874. Andrews sailed from Boston the next month. It would be a totally new venture.

The church had no policy framework ready for an overseas mission, nor were their expectations of results altogether realistic. Church leaders hoped that the mission would be able to support itself in a very short time. This proved not possible. They also assumed that sharing the message of the three angels would be as easy in Europe as it had been in America and that the methods that

worked so well in America would also work just as easily in this new "Macedonia." This too was unrealistic. Expectations and assumptions had to be reassessed, as the mission grew more slowly and cost much more than expected. The needs of this "Macedonia" were also different.

The response to this call required not only evangelistic passion and preaching skills. It also required skill in pastoral understanding and pastoral care. James White thought that the assigned worker should not waste time in solving pastoral problems; just push on with evangelistic endeavor. But the pastoral hurts in Switzerland ran deep, and Andrews had to be a pastor before he could be an effective evangelist.

Unlike Lydia, the dealer in purple cloth who in Philippi apparently had ready resources to assist Paul in his new mission, the Swiss believers and John Andrews found themselves with very few funds. Just before Andrews arrived, the network of relatives that formed the Sabbathkeeping community had invested heavily in an industrial restructuring. This was partly an effort to recover losses over the failed missionary publishing outreach, and also to rejuvenate their watchmaking industry. The endeavor soaked up funds and energy. Furthermore, the negative attitudes created in the communities over the scandalous departure of Czechowski lingered on and created deep prejudice against the witnessing of Sabbathkeepers and against a ready reception of Andrews' own preaching.

Andrews' pastoral ministry trying to reach through cultural and language barriers was not at first successful. But he believed that the call had indeed been the call of God, and he persevered. He launched a missionary magazine, *Les Signes des Temps*, and preached wherever and whenever he could. Others came to help him, and the small Adventist mission grew. It reached into Germany, into France, into Italy, and even down to Egypt. This "Macedonia" might be different, but the call of God was the same. And the church grew. ♣

Gilbert M. Valentine, Ph.D., is retired from teaching at the School of Education at La Sierra University and now teaches occasionally at the H.M.S. Richards Divinity School as an adjunct.

OUR MISSION: URGENT!

*Are you in,
or are you out?*

MICHAEL L. RYAN



The church is God's appointed agency for the salvation of men. It was organized for service, and its mission is to carry the gospel to the world.**

AN INCREDIBLE JESUS

The Bible records an incredible Jesus. Never is there any indication that He missed an opportunity to minister to the hopeless. In Matthew 8 and 9 we are given a two-day glimpse of Jesus' schedule, His side trips, the vast diversity of His ministry, and His strong passion for building the kingdom.

Having delivered His longest sermon, Jesus navigates down the mountain through a crowd desperate for hope. Jesus, not missing one person, inches toward the city of Capernaum. En route a

leper asks if He would be willing to heal him. The words "I am willing" pierce the air, and the man instantly begins a new life.

Jesus enters the city and finds a Roman officer begging for his servant's life. I can hear Jesus telling Peter, "I'll be at your house shortly, but first I will go with this centurion."

"No, not necessary," cries the Roman. "Just say the word." Instantly Jesus inserts into His day a sermonette commending such faith and chastising the faithless Jews. Then Christ utters to the centurion life-changing words that should echo in the ears of today's mission generation: "Go your way; and as you have believed, so let it be done for you" (Matt. 8:13).



Finally Jesus enters Peter's home and finds death lingering nearby. But death has no power when the Life-giver is present. He heals Peter's mother-in-law and works far into the night, ministering to desperate people.

A GREAT STORM

Looking about, Jesus still sees a great multitude. But divine foreknowledge tells Jesus He has missionaries to commission beyond the lake. He commands the disciples to leave immediately. Walk-

ing to the boat, He debunks the insincerity of those who claim they will follow Him but are so embroiled in the affairs of this world that their urgency and conviction fade.

Halfway across the lake a great storm unleashes its fury, and Jesus is awakened to calm the wind and sea, but, more important, to restore sinking faith.

I can hear Jesus joyfully say, upon arriving, "There are the missionaries I am to commission." In shock, the disciples see two dirty, dangerous, wild, devil-possessed lunatics streaming down the hill. Jesus heals the two, sends the demons into a herd of pigs, and sends His new missionaries to tell the world about the kingdom. He then rebuffs the grumpy, self-serving hometown crowd and travels back to Capernaum.

There He teaches the temple scribes a lesson on forgiving sins. He forgives the sins of a man with palsy, and to make sure the scribes get the point that He is able to forgive sins, He heals the man before their very eyes.

En route to the city Jesus stops long enough to call Matthew to the ministry with the shortest evangelism appeal on record: "Follow Me." Without a word Matthew follows Him.

Soon after, Jesus eats with publicans and sinners invited by Matthew, and kindly rebuffs the disciples of John the Baptist when they question His banqueting while they are fasting.

Jesus then leaves the dinner to resurrect the dead daughter of a temple ruler. On this errand of mercy He has to endure mockery over His describing death as sleep. But even before arriving at the ruler's house, He embraces the faith of a woman who touches His garment and is instantly healed. On the way home He heals two blind men and a dumb man by casting a demon out of him.

In these and many other examples, Jesus worked to reach people with urgency.

For Christians, involvement in God's mission and experiencing personal transformation while being in but not of this world is not optional.

There is a temptation to avoid such involvement and create a definition of mission that keeps you comfortable. Only Holy Spirit-inspired prayer and sacrifice, however, can truly move mission forward. Avoidance of such will not be found in the mission landscape of the church. Challenges are, of course, expected, but one can choose to see them as barriers or as opportunities.

THE OPPORTUNITIES

With 23 million members in a world of more than 8 billion people, how can we miss missionally responding to such diversity? In the world today, 26 percent are Muslim, 16 percent are atheist, 15 percent are Hindu, 7 percent are Buddhist, and 4 percent are animist. That's more than 5 billion non-Christians. Nearly 50 percent of the world's population is below the poverty line. There are more than 7,000 languages and at least 4,000 separate cultures worldwide.

In 1800 more than 95 percent of the world's population lived in rural areas, but now more than 55 percent live in urban areas, with 68 percent projected by 2050.

For Christians, involvement in God's mission and experiencing personal transformation while being in but not of this world is not optional.

More than 40 percent of the world is younger than 24; nearly 50 percent is between 25 and 64 years old, and 10 percent is older than 64.

Of approximately 230 self-governing entities, the Seventh-day Adventist Church has a presence in all but 17 of them. Inside those numbers, however, lies good news and opportunity news.

Nearly 70 percent of the world lives inside the 10/40 window, a territory between 10 degrees and 40 degrees north of the equator, stretching from Spain and Morocco to Japan. Inside that window live the great populations of other world religions, but only 12 percent of all Adventists. It's impossible to miss the harvest field!

STANDING IN LINE

If the population of each country were to stand in a line and every second, one person were to pass by, how long would it take for a Seventh-day Adventist to walk by? In the Philippines, an Adventist would walk by every 10.9 seconds. In Papua New Guinea, it would take only 5.9 seconds. And on Pitcairn Island, nearly two would pass by every second.

There are other territories, however, where worry wrinkles dominate the mission landscape. In the city of Kolkata, India, it would take 7.5 days to see the first Adventist. In Iran it would take 84.5 days, and 295.7 days in North Korea.

In this article I can parade what I might hope would divinely inspire, shake, and awaken mission urgency in the membership of the church. Mission urgency is present, but the question is: Am I part of it?

Thankfully, the Bible is packed with "go ye" statements: "This gospel of the kingdom will be preached" (Matt. 24:14) (instruction); "teach," "baptize," "every nation, tribe, tongue, and people" (Rev. 14:6) (appeals); "Who shall I send?" "Here am I! Send me" (Isa. 6:8) (questions and answers); "Prepare the way of the Lord" (Isa. 40:3) (commands); and "I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness: 'Make straight the way of the Lord'" (John 1:23) (testimonies).

I love the divine instruction, but I am not sure it's the only motivator for mission. From eternity

past to eternity future, Jesus' life will stand as the greatest motivational example of mission urgency, mission passion, and mission refocus, as we have seen by sampling just two days of His ministry.

URGENCY AND MISSION REFOCUS

As we contemplate the degree of our urgency to build the kingdom, practice compassion, attend evangelism meetings, check the oil in our lamps, and throw off the bushel darkening our candles, do we come anywhere near understanding the passion and urgency of Christ's ministry? Impossibilities do not change God's instructions. Holy Spirit power makes the mission possible and moves it forward.

In our sixteenth year of mission service my wife and I will never forget hearing the announcement at the 1990 General Conference Session that, for the first time, the worldwide church was establishing one new church per day. We were thrilled!

Today the church has radically increased its refocus on mission. Prayer, sacrifice, and mission are blazing on the front burner of the church.

Here are a few examples:

- In 2023 Global Mission reported that a new church is planted every 2.97 hours!
- Global Mission, following Ellen White's instruction, works in partnership to establish hundreds of urban centers of influence scattered throughout the massive cities of the 10/40 window.
- The Great Controversy Project 2.0 digital advertisement initiative now reports more than 10,000 English-speaking people a day responding to digital ads, downloading *The Great Controversy*, and taking Bible studies.
- Global Bible School, a new Publishing Ministries and Sabbath School/Personal Ministries initiative in partnership with Adventist World Radio, is expecting to generate millions of Bible study interests in numerous languages during the coming months.

Courage! God's church will not fail! The signs of the times tell us that the Holy Spirit's earthquake of hope is shaking the world.

Are you in, or are you out? 🍷

* Ellen G. White, *The Acts of the Apostles* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1911), p. 9.

Michael L. Ryan has served as a missionary in Asia, director of Global Mission, and vice president of the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists, and currently is an assistant to the president of the General Conference."

THE IMPORTANCE OF PROPHECY

Our anchor for faith

The day after my new birth (fall of 1979)—converted but clueless, utterly—I met three Christians in a health food store. Knowing nothing about them or their beliefs, I said that I wanted to study the Bible. *What do you want to study?* “I want to study about America. Is America in Bible prophecy?”

Picture this: I did not know that they were Seventh-day Adventists. Had I, it would have meant nothing. And yet the first thing that I ask them, Seventh-day Adventists, to study with me is—*America in prophecy?*

Since then, as an Adventist, I have studied, and still study, prophecy. (After all, we are a prophetic movement, right?) And though some (and perhaps at times justly) complain about all the winged-lions and 10-horned-dragons and talking-horn and smashed-statue imagery used in our evangelism, all this winged-lion and 10-horned-dragon and talking-horn and smashed-statue imagery have, over the decades, helped affirm me in my faith.

For example, I defy anyone to explain how, without a God knowing the future, Daniel 2 could have predicted not only the rise of Rome but also its breakup into the nations of modern Europe, and so accurately, too (some weak, some strong; crossbreeding among themselves; still divided). To this day, Daniel 2 and Daniel 7 (with its astonishing depiction of papal Rome) remain rational anchors firmly tethering me to my faith.

Meanwhile, besides the complaints about winged lions and 10-horned dragons and so forth, there is sometimes bruited about among us the idea that we should not focus so much on prophecy because it’s not that important. Instead, we should be focusing on “the love of

Jesus.” Now please, I am not against the love of Jesus, or even a more focused emphasis on it. In fact, I have a book coming out soon tentatively titled *How to Know the Love of God*. But it doesn’t have to be one or the other. If done correctly, prophecy is an expression of Christ’s love, because it’s another way of His revealing truth about Himself, and that is important.

And this importance hit me while reading *The Desire of Ages* and seeing the confusion, including among Jesus’ own followers, about Him and His ministry. And that confusion came, at least partially, because the people didn’t understand Bible prophecy, Bible prophecy about His first coming. They got it wrong, expecting a military and political Messiah who would deliver them from the Romans. What none expected was a meek and humble Messiah with no political pretensions, which helps explain why they rejected Him. Some of the leaders were jealous, fearful for their own power and influence, that’s true. But what helped justify the rejection of Jesus was their gross misreading of Bible prophecy. And so, instead of falling down before their Messiah in humility and repentance, as they should have—had they understood the prophecies—they cursed and mocked and derided the Messiah after they put Him on a cross.



SCAN ME

Editor’s Note: This is an excerpt of a longer column online. Please scan the QR code or type the link into a search engine (<https://bit.ly/cliff1024>) to continue reading this and other columns.

CLIFF’S
EDGE
CLIFFORD
GOLDSTEIN



IF DONE
CORRECTLY,
PROPHECY IS AN
EXPRESSION OF
CHRIST’S LOVE.

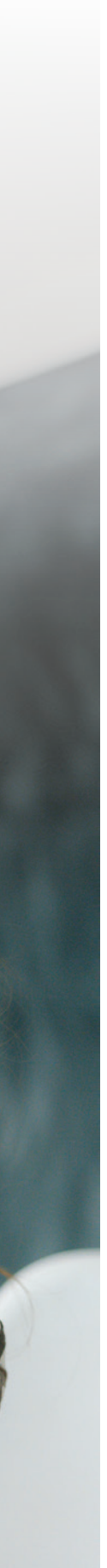
Clifford Goldstein is the editor of the *Adult Bible Study Guide*. His latest book is *An Adventist Journey*, published by the Inter-American Division Publishing Association (IADPA).

GRACE FOR MISSIONARY KIDS

*When becoming
a missionary
isn't your choice*

LYNETTE YOON





I was angry at God. I thought He was trying to ruin my life. My parents had just told me that they felt God was calling them to be missionaries, but I did not want to be a missionary. I had my life planned out, and it did not involve going to serve in the middle of nowhere with my parents!

I also thought it was impossible to move overseas, because my mother's health was so poor; she had been in a wheelchair for the past couple of years with chronic fatigue syndrome. My parents decided to make my mother's health the test of their calling, and at an anointing service she was instantly healed.

I couldn't deny God's call to my family. Although I still felt a little reluctant, I accompanied them for missionary training, moving from the United Kingdom to the United States. Becoming a missionary kid (MK) would be a pivotal point in my life, bringing gifts I couldn't yet imagine.

CHOSEN FOR US

Missionary kids are launched into an adventure typically not of their own choosing. They belong to a demographic called "third culture kids" (TCKs)—people who grow up in multiple cultures and typically move around a lot, often because of their parents' work.

Being a missionary TCK presents both unique challenges to navigate and blessings to experi-

ence, as numerous TCKs besides me can testify—including Anna, who was an MK in Germany, and Stephen, who was an MK in Europe and the United States.

A great blessing is that missionary life often provides exciting new experiences and growth opportunities, both personally and spiritually.

Anna loved her multicultural environment, and particularly remembers visiting a large community of African refugees. It was a treat for her to enjoy spicy food while she sat on the floor and ate with her hands. Her family also made several trips into Romania after the fall of Ceausescu, to bring aid to hospitals and orphanages. Those trips made a profound impact on young Anna. She says, "My heart was broken open by the Lord's compassion (His suffering with us), and I longed to become His compassion in this aching world."

Anna considered even the mistakes she made as an MK to be an advantage. All her blunders taught her to rely on God's help and guidance, helping her to be willing to release her own understanding in exchange for God's (see Prov. 3:5).

Stephen also enjoyed the exposure to different cultures and worldviews, learning to listen with an open mind and appreciate the shared beauty of the human experience. "Being an MK has allowed me to identify common ground with others, no matter where I am in the world," he says.

I too grew as an MK. I had always been shy, but my missionary experience enabled me to bloom. Conquering fears, overcoming language barriers, and finding myself up front as an English teacher helped me become confident. My spiritual life was stretched and enriched by seeing the great controversy play out in clearer ways.

IT'S NOT ALWAYS GREAT

As much as there are benefits to being a missionary kid, there can also be some painful challenges.

Anna lived in 23 “houses” in her first 23 years of life (including a camper van). This continual uprooting left her hungry for a place to truly feel at home. She tried to fill that ache in unhealthy ways, before God helped her understand His true compassion for her and that she had a home in His heart.

Stephen discovered that as he grew older, he, at times, struggled with decision-making. He excelled at adapting to ever-changing environments, responding to high-stress situations and external motivators. But the inner work of making certain choices *for himself*—where to live, how long for, and what really mattered outside of work—could feel crippling.

Research shows that missionary kids are at particularly high risk of adverse childhood experiences (potentially traumatic experiences within their household and wider environment).¹ There may be dangers of living in a hostile country, and struggles in adapting to a different culture, but there are other challenges that MKs experience too. For instance, one study found that two out of five missionary kids felt unloved or unimportant to their parents. And they were four times more likely than their American peers to experience emotional abuse.²

There are ways, however, to mitigate these hazards. When a child's parents, community, and sending organization are aware of the risks and learn how to support MKs, they can provide safeguarding and positive experiences that help MKs build a healthy future.

The consequences of growing up as an MK can range from positive to negative, but whatever the highs and lows, God's grace is always there for the missionary kid.

INCLUDED IN THE CALL

God revealed to me that even as He called my parents to mission, He remembered *me* in that call. While I've had my share of grief to process, following God led me to many adventures in Southeast Asia, the United States, England, and now Korea. I have been shaped for the better and given many gifts, including a growing awareness of God's kindness and creativity in my life.

Just as I have experienced God's compassion, so have Anna and Stephen.

Anna comments, “God remains faithful even when we are faithless.”

And Stephen realized that in contrast to the often-temporary relationships he experienced moving around as an MK, God's friendship was consistent. He says, “God holds more grace toward us than we could ever comprehend. When you feel like there is nothing for you, God turns up. When you don't know who you are inside, God reminds you of your identity. When you push God away in frustration, He never holds it against you. The way God has continually turned up for me, no matter what my heart posture has been, is nothing short of abundant grace.”

While MKs may often find that their adventure starts in a way that is beyond their control, God's calling is for them, too. Even if MKs feel overlooked, out of place, or lonely at times, God does not forget them. He tends to them lovingly. His heart aches for their pain. God works with them and through them, just as much as He does their missionary parents. And God's goodness and mercy pursues missionary kids for all the days of their lives (see Ps. 23:6). ▀

Even as God
called my parents
to mission,
He remembered
me in that call.

¹ T. Crossman, *Caution and Hope for Missionary Kids*, retrieved July 19, 2024, from *Caution and Hope for Missionary Kids* (tck-training.com).

² T. Crossman and L. McCall, *Mitigating Risk Factors for Missionary Kids*, retrieved July 19, 2024, from *Mitigating Risk Factors for Mission Kids* (tcktraining.com).

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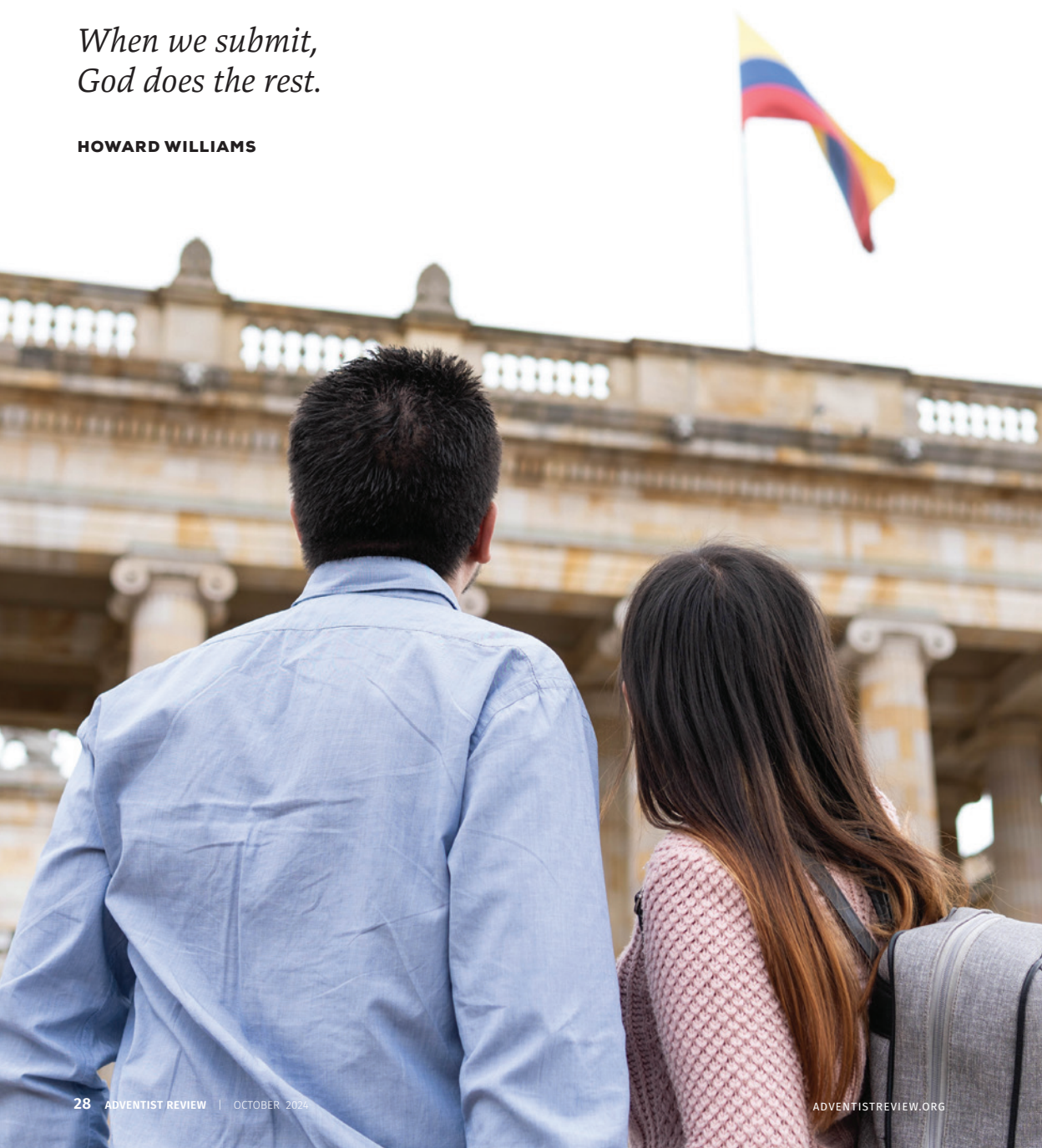


...ENCOURAGING
YOUNG PEOPLE
TO LEARN,
EXPERIENCE,
LIVE AND
SHARE CHRIST

IMPECCABLE TIMING

*When we submit,
God does the rest.*

HOWARD WILLIAMS





There we were, young country kids in a city of some 3 million people.

It was an evening in the fall of 1974. My father invited my young wife and I to come over to their house to meet a family who were involved in missionary work in Colombia. I wanted to become a missionary, so the invitation was accepted. Long story short, about a month and a half later we found ourselves in Colombia working as volunteers for the winter.

As per the instructions we received, we didn't carry much cash with us; instead we had my parents send us a check every couple of months, which we would then cash at the conference office in Bogota. The first check arrived as we were running low on money, so we made the long trip to the capital city, arriving with only a few pesos left. When I had opened the letter with the check in it, I had placed the check in my shirt pocket while I read the letter. The next day when I asked my wife where my shirt was, she said she had washed it in the river, and it was drying on the line. When we presented the washed check to the cashier, he took one look at it and informed us that the bank would not accept it because of the damage to one digit. It looked fine to us, but we could not convince him otherwise.

FULL SUBMISSION

We exited the building and sat on the steps processing our plight. There we were, young country kids in a city of some 3 million people. We knew no one. We didn't even have enough money to buy supper that day. As we grappled with the seriousness of our situation, my wife began to cry, and when a well-dressed gentleman passed by, I'm sure my face looked pretty long as well. As he reached the top of the steps he stopped, turned around, and asked, "Are you guys all right?" Out came our story mingled with a few tears. "Don't worry!" he replied. "Give me about 15 minutes, and I will take you to my house. You can stay there till more money arrives. By the way, I am Henry Niemann, the conference president."

He took us to his home, treated us like his own children, lent us some money to get around the city, and even invited us to accompany him on some trips to see the countryside.

This experience was a turning point in our young lives. Up till then, God was purely theoretical. Now His watch care over us became real. He had immediately taken care of the single greatest need we had ever experienced. When we returned home, it was only a short time before we became involved in a home Bible study group. On the very first night we learned that the reason we had struggled so much in our walk with God was that we had never fully submitted our lives to His leading. That very night at home on my knees, I did just that.

I have often pondered the extent of the logistics God arranged in order to get that letter where He needed it to be at precisely the right time He needed it to get there.

A few months went by, and I found out from Elder Niemann that he was making plans to start an agricultural boarding academy where poor children could attend and work off their entire tuition. The place he wanted to buy land was nearly solid jungle, and all the land would need to be cleared so that farming could be done. He wondered if I would be interested in helping in such a project, since I came from an equipment operator/logging background. If so, he would look into getting visas for us.

I was thrilled! Not many opportunities come up for loggers to go to the mission field. As I considered the plan, it occurred to me that they would need a good bulldozer to do all that clearing. Our family's logging business had three bulldozers. I excitedly approached the other partners with a question: Would they consider donating a bulldozer to the conference in Colombia? I proposed, not our newest machine, but the next-newest one. I was shocked when they insisted that if we were going to give God a machine, it had to be our best one. Everyone agreed. I immediately wrote a letter to Elder Niemann with the news.

GOD'S PLAN

Fast-forward a couple weeks. The executive committee met, and one of the agenda items for the day was whether or not to proceed with the agricultural school plan. Not all the members were on board with the idea, and the discussion ran into lunchtime. "Gentlemen," Elder Niemann said, "let's table the discussion till after lunch break. Go home, pray over this issue, and after lunch we will take the final vote."

When Elder Niemann passed through the lobby of the conference office after lunch, the receptionist called out his name with the announcement that he had received a letter from the United States. Reaching his office, he opened my letter and read it. When the executive committee meeting reconvened, he had something to share with them. "Brethren," he declared, "I have a letter I want to read to you. Afterward we will take our vote." With that, he read the letter. It was quiet for a few minutes. Then he called for the vote. It was unanimous: Yes.

They could never get visas for my wife and me, but the school was built without us. And as far as the donated bulldozer was concerned, they could never figure out a way to get it there. The point is that God didn't need our bulldozer or us. All He needed was for me to write a letter to them offering to donate a bulldozer. That was what God chose to use to convince the committee to move ahead with the plan. A plan, I might add, that was His plan.

I have often pondered the extent of the logistics God arranged in order to get that letter where He needed it to be at precisely the right time He needed it to get there.

He had sent a couple from Florida to Arcata, California, to meet a family who knew that my dad had a small portable sawmill a two-hour drive out in the hills; there they met me and my wife and convinced us to go to Colombia with them. God then permitted our check to get damaged, leaving us destitute on the conference office steps in Bogota right on time to meet Elder Niemann. Then after we were back in the United States and learned to submit our lives to Him fully, God impressed us to donate the bulldozer and write that letter to Elder Niemann. He then made sure the letter arrived at lunchtime on the very day of the committee meeting that was deciding the fate of the proposed academy. God has impeccable timing!

Friends, we serve an awesome God! For those who are genuinely submissive to Him, these kinds of experiences become pretty common, but they never lose their "awe" factor! 🍂

Howard Williams, a retired missionary and pastor who served in Bolivia, the Philippines, Alaska, and Idaho, lives in central Oregon.

OUR PRIMARY CALLING

You might be surprised.

If I was to share a quote from Ellen White that started like this, “Of all professed Christians, Seventh-day Adventists should be foremost in uplifting . . .” and asked you to complete the sentence, what would you say?

Seventh-day Adventists should be foremost in uplifting . . . the Sabbath? the Second Coming? the state of the dead? the three angels’ messages? the health message?

Perhaps you’d be surprised at her answer.

“Of all professed Christians,” she wrote in 1891, “Seventh-day Adventists should be foremost in uplifting *Christ* before the world.”¹

For those of us who are dyed-in-the-wool Seventh-day Adventists, and who have a heart for our unique mission and calling, her answer may catch us off guard. We’ve typically framed our purpose as focusing on matters that aren’t understood or emphasized by other faith communities.

Thus, we talk a lot about the Sabbath, what happens when a person dies, Christ’s return, the investigative judgment, or healthy eating—all things that fall under the banner of what we often label “present truth.”

Bringing emphasis to these topics is, in many ways, the reason for our existence.

Thus, we seem to imply, other Protestant denominations can preach Jesus; we’ll bring them “present truth.”

And yet, at least according to Ellen White in 1891, nobody should talk more about Jesus than Seventh-day Adventists. Indeed, as I like to say, no one should “out-Jesus” us.

This isn’t to say, of course, that “present truth” and Jesus are in conflict with each other or that they’re necessarily even different subjects. As I’ve pointed out a number of times in various places,

Adventist theology is never more beautiful and powerful than when it is understood and presented in the light of Jesus—and Jesus is never more attractive than when the depth of His character is explained through these various facets of “present truth” (so long, of course, as those various facets are truly saturated with the dynamism of Christ).²

But the larger point is that we as Adventists should be the head and not the tail when it comes to our emphasis on and living out the reality of Jesus. We should make much of Him. We should regularly speak of His love and dwell upon His sacrifice.

And we should talk about other themes only as they are connected to Christ and His love.

Elsewhere, Ellen White made this very point: “The sacrifice of Christ as an atonement for sin is the great truth around which all other truths cluster,” she explained in 1901. “This is to be the foundation of every discourse given by our ministers.”³

Simply put, no Adventist should ever preach a Christless or crossless sermon. Nor should any person, preacher or otherwise, center our faith on anyone or anything else. Jesus is where our power resides. He is how our lives are transformed. He is the reason for our existence.

Indeed, no person—or denomination—should be able to “out-Jesus” Adventists. 🍷

¹ Ellen G. White, *The Ellen G. White 1888 Materials* (Washington, D.C.: Ellen G. White Estate, 1987), vol. 2, p. 891. (Italics supplied.)

² See, for example, my book *There’s More to Jesus: Encountering the Fullness of Christ in Adventism* (Warburton, Victoria: Signs Publishing, 2016).

³ Ellen G. White, *Evangelism* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1946), p. 190.

Shawn Brace is an author, pastor, and church planter in Portland, Maine, who is also pursuing a D.Phil. in Ecclesiastical History at Oxford University.

REIMAGINING
FAITH
SHAWN
BRACE



NO ADVENTIST
SHOULD EVER
PREACH A
CHRISTLESS OR
CROSSLESS
SERMON.



AN ANGEL OF GOD

DELAYED

*Rules of engagement in
the cosmic conflict*

JOHN PECKHAM



A story is told of a very wealthy man who refused to provide any funds to help those less fortunate. The people of his town think he is greedy and selfish. But, after he dies, their perception of this man totally changes when the contents of his will are revealed. His will includes instructions to leave all his wealth to the poor and explains further that he inherited his wealth from a relative who made him promise never to give the money to others during his lifetime and never to reveal this promise during his lifetime.¹ Further, he lived on only the barest necessities during his life so he could leave as much of the fortune as possible to the needy. This further information revealed that the man, far from being a greedy miser, was in fact very benevolent and generous.

In our day many people hold deep misunderstandings about the character of God, especially when it comes to suffering and tragedies. Here too there is much more to the story than meets the eye. Even as the wealthy man's will changed the way he was perceived, understanding what God has revealed in Scripture about the cosmic conflict illuminates God's character.

AN ANGEL WITHSTOOD FOR THREE WEEKS

A striking example of this cosmic conflict appears in Daniel 10, in which a message is revealed to Daniel about "a great conflict" (Dan. 10:1, NRSV). Greatly concerned, Daniel mourned, fasted, and fervently prayed for "three full weeks" (verse 2).²

After these three weeks Daniel saw a "great vision" and went into "a deep sleep" (verses 8, 9). Then a hand touched Daniel, and he heard the words "O Daniel, man greatly beloved, understand the words that I speak to you, and stand upright, for I have now been sent to you. . . . Do not fear, Daniel, for from the first day that you set your heart to understand, and to humble yourself before your God, your words were heard; and I have come because of your words" (verses 11, 12).

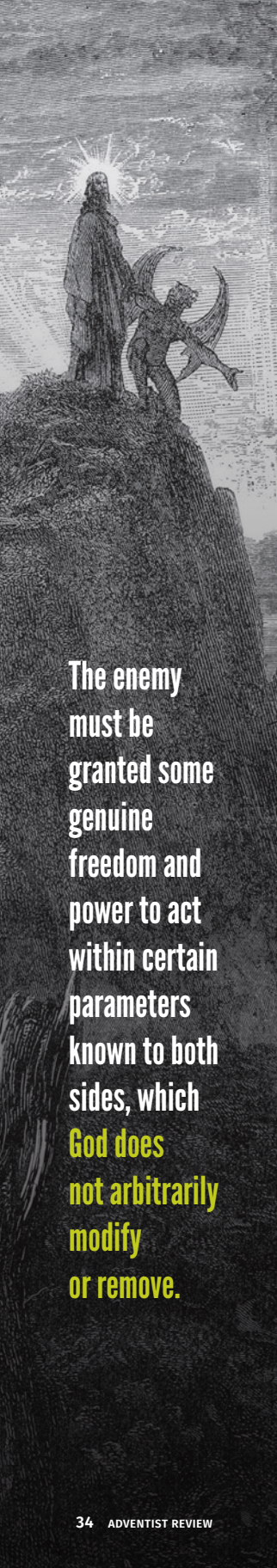
Notice that Daniel's words were heard "from the first day." Three weeks ago. Why did this angel come to Daniel only after three full weeks? The angel himself answers this question: "But the prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood me twenty-one days," and the angel came only after Michael "came to help" him (verse 13).³

How is this possible? How could an angel sent by God be "withstood" for three weeks?

God is all-powerful (see, e.g., Jer. 32:17; Rev. 19:6) and therefore possessed the power to respond immediately to Daniel's prayers. But here God's angel is delayed for three entire weeks!

This case presents a serious conflict between the forces of light and darkness. For this to take place, however, God must not be exercising all His power. The enemy must be granted some genuine freedom and power to act within certain parameters (or rules) known to both sides, which God does not arbitrarily modify or remove.

As I have explained in a previous article, this cosmic conflict between God's kingdom and the devil's domain of darkness cannot be one of



The enemy must be granted some genuine freedom and power to act within certain parameters known to both sides, which God does not arbitrarily modify or remove.

sheer power.⁴ No creature could oppose God at the level of sheer power. This conflict must be one of another kind.

Scripture elsewhere identifies this as a conflict over character, caused by the devil's slanderous allegations against God that he raises in the heavenly court (and beyond) as the "accuser of our brethren, who accused them before our God day and night" (Rev. 12:10; cf. Gen. 3:1-5; Job 1-2; Zech. 3:1, 2; Jude 9). Since slanderous allegations cannot be settled by force, God can effectively answer these allegations only through a demonstration that proves them false. This kind of conflict is possible only if God has committed Himself to work within some parameters in which His kingdom can be opposed, which I call rules of engagement.

THE RULES OF ENGAGEMENT

The idea that God commits Himself to working within some specified parameters (or "rules") might seem strange to you at first, but it is actually a common occurrence throughout Scripture.

Consider this. Does God make promises? Indeed He does. Repeatedly throughout Scripture God makes promises and enters into covenants with His people wherein He specifies not only what He expects of them, but what He Himself will assuredly do.

Does God ever break His promises? Never. In fact, Scripture teaches that God "cannot deny Himself" (2 Tim. 2:13), that He never lies (Titus 1:2), and that His promises are unbreakable (Heb. 6:17, 18; see also Ps. 89:34).

Given this, to the extent that God makes a promise or commits Himself (whether in a formal covenant or otherwise), God has thereby morally restricted His future actions to be in accord with whatever He has promised or committed Himself.

But why would God commit Himself to any such parameters, or "rules," in the first place, especially in the cosmic conflict?

Imagine I am playing a board game with my son. The game is not going my way, so I decide to simply change my son's moves so that I win. Wait, my son would surely protest, calling my changes unfair! And he would be right. If I were just to use my power to change his moves whenever I wanted so that I could have the advantage or win at every turn, my son would have no chance to win. The entire contest would be nothing but a charade and would show me to be profoundly unfair.

Every analogy breaks down. But at least in some ways this analogy might help us to see what might take place if God did not afford the enemy some room to make his case in the cosmic conflict in order to defeat the devil's allegations in a way that is best for all creatures in the universe.

As noted earlier, the cosmic conflict is a conflict over character in which the devil has lodged allegations against God's character and God's government in the heavenly court. And the only way such allegations can be effectively countered and defeated is not by force, but by a demonstration.

In this context the enemy claims that he could prove his case against God's character and government, if only given the chance. We see glimpses of this claim throughout Scripture, such as in the book of Job, when Satan appears before the heavenly council (see Job 1:6) and raises slanderous allegations against a righteous man named Job (verses 9-11; Job 2:4, 5). By charging that Job is unrighteous, Satan also thereby alleges that God is an unrighteous judge, for God had already declared Job "a blameless and upright

man, one who fears God and shuns evil” (Job 1:8; 2:3). Then Satan argues that he could prove his case if it were not for the fact that God had “made a hedge around” Job (Job 1:10), indicating some parameters, or rules, restricting the devil’s actions.⁵

This is one of many biblical examples of what I call rules of engagement, some parameters related to court proceedings in the heavenly council within which the arch-accuser Satan is allowed to make his cosmic courtroom case against God’s justice and love. Because God will never lie or break any promises or commitments He has made, God’s future actions are limited (morally) to be in accordance with whatever parameters to which He has agreed in the heavenly court. Accordingly, the devil has some real power and jurisdiction within which he works in this world, a point that is highlighted throughout Scripture.

For example, when he tempted Jesus in the wilderness, the devil showed Christ “all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time” and said, “All this authority I will give You, and their glory; for this has been delivered to me, and I give it to whomever I wish. Therefore, if You will worship before me, all will be Yours” (Luke 4:5-7; see also Matt. 8:29; 12:24-29; Rev. 12-13).⁶ Likewise, Christ Himself refers to the devil as “the ruler of this world” (John 12:31; 14:30; 16:11; cf. 2 Cor. 4:4; 1 Peter 5:8) and John writes that “the whole world lies under the sway of the wicked one” (1 John 5:19; see also Acts 26:18; Eph. 6:11, 12).

HOPE IN LOVE

While many more questions remain, this provides a framework for why evil sometimes seems to run rampant in our world. This world looks like a war zone because it is one.

People often ask: “Why didn’t God prevent that evil event?” This framework supports the following answer: He would if He “could.”

Now, don’t misunderstand. This does not mean God lacks any power. Rather, this answer highlights that since God is entirely good (see Deut. 32:4) and hates evil more than we do, God would prevent any evil event if He “could” do so *without denying His nature* (2 Tim. 2:13), *breaking His promises* (Heb. 6:17, 18), or *otherwise undermining love or resulting in worse outcomes on the whole* (see, e.g., Rom. 8:18-20, 28, 37-39).

While we might think God should have taken this or that course of action, for all we know such courses were not *morally* available to God. While God wants

to prevent every evil, doing so in some cases would either undermine free will (and thus love itself), be against the rules of engagement to which God has committed in the heavenly court, or result in greater evil or less flourishing of love.

Again, our world looks like a war zone because it is one. It is not a war of sheer power, but one over love itself. Through the work of Christ, God makes a way to defeat darkness forever without compromising goodness and love.

This cosmic war will not go on forever, and thus the devil “knows that he has a short time” (Rev. 12:12; see also Rom. 16:20). One day soon God will put an end to evil, suffering, and death once and for all and wipe away every tear (Rev. 21:4).

What can we do in the midst of it?

First, take hope that God is love and that victory is assured. Christ has assured victory for all who have faith in Him via the cross—“neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities nor powers, nor things present nor things to come, nor height nor depth, nor any other created thing, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Rom. 8:38, 39).

Second, spread love and hope to others. God is working. He calls you to work as well. Many things are not as God wants. He calls you and me to be a force for good in the world. So you are called not only to take hope in the true King, but to give someone else hope by making a difference for good in their life today—in defiance against this present darkness, in the name of the true King. 📌

⁵ This story is adapted from William Abraham, “Revelation Reaffirmed,” in *Divine Revelation*, ed. Paul Avis (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1997), p. 208.

⁶ On prayer in the midst of cosmic conflict, see John C. Peckham, *Why We Pray: Understanding Prayer in the Context of Cosmic Conflict* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2024).

³ Many scholars believe this “prince” of Persia is a demonic ruler working behind Persia’s human ruler (cf. Dan. 10:20, 21). See, e.g., Tremper Longman III, *Daniel* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1999), p. 250. Even if it was merely a human ruler, however, Daniel 10 portrays God’s angel working within limits that delay him from answering Daniel’s prayer for 21 days.

⁴ See John Peckham, “Why Evil? An Enemy Has Done This,” *Adventist Review*, September 2024, pp. 30-33.

⁵ Regarding the story of Job, see John C. Peckham, *Theodicy of Love: Cosmic Conflict and the Problem of Evil* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2018), pp. 73-82, 94-100.

⁶ In Revelation 12-13 we are taught that the dragon (identified as the devil) is the ruler standing behind the earthly kingdoms and powers that work against God and His people (Rev. 13:2).

John Peckham is associate editor of *Adventist Review* and research professor of theology and Christian philosophy at Andrews University.

SABBATH INSTITUTED AT CREATION

*Restoring the honor and
sanctity of God's holy day*

ELLEN G. WHITE

The Lord has a special message for His ambassadors to bear. They are to give the people the warning, calling upon them to repair the breach that has been made by the papacy in the law of God. The Sabbath has been made a nonentity, an unessential requirement, which human authority can set aside. The holy day of the Lord has been changed to a common working day. Men have torn down God's memorial, placing a false rest day in its stead.

SABBATH . . . GOD'S ULTIMATE BLESSING

The Lord's messengers are not to sanction any plan whereby the Sabbath will be trodden underfoot. The Sabbath is God's memorial of creation. He did not make holy and bless the first day of His creation. After he had finished the work of creating the world, He blessed the seventh day, setting it apart for man to honor.

Human authority has taken the first working day and set it apart to be honored. But this act has not one word of sanction from the high and holy One who inhabiteth eternity. Thus God has been greatly dishonored.

God designed every Sabbath to be a day for religious meditation and worship. "The Lord spake unto Moses, saying, Speak thou also unto the children of Israel, saying, Verily, my Sabbaths ye shall keep; for it is a sign between me and you throughout your generations; that ye may know that I am the Lord that doth sanctify you. Ye shall keep the Sabbath therefore, for it is holy unto you; every one that defileth it shall surely be put to death; for whosoever doeth any work therein, that soul shall be put off from among his people.

"Six days may work be done, but in the seventh is the Sabbath of rest, holy to the Lord; whosoever doeth any work in the Sabbath day, he shall surely be put to death. Wherefore the children of Israel shall keep the Sabbath to observe the Sabbath throughout their generations for a perpetual covenant. It is a sign between men and the children of Israel forever; for in six days the Lord made heaven and earth, and on the seventh day he rested, and was refreshed" [Exodus 31:12-17].

The foundation of many generations is to be raised up from being trampled under the feet of men. It is to be exalted and called honorable.

Christ gave His life for sinful human beings. Thus He made it possible for them to win back by obedience what they had lost. He longed to save those who had been led into sin, and He gave His life as a sacrifice, that men and women might have ample opportunity and every incentive to return to their allegiance. Thus he made it possible for them to keep his holy law and to stand on vantage ground before the heavenly universe. . . .

A MESSAGE OF ETERNAL IMPORTANCE

A message is to be borne to the churches who are walking in transgression of God's law. God says, "If thou turn away thy foot from the Sabbath, from doing thy pleasure on my holy day," no longer desecrating it, I will receive you as My children [Isaiah 58:13]. God has a message for the sinners in Zion. The warning must be given to the churches. "Cry aloud, spare not, lift up thy voice like a trumpet" [verse



1]. Be decided and in earnest. Make no concessions with transgressors. Bear the message God has given, that transgressors may be given opportunity to repent and be restored to the favor of God.

This is the work before Seventh-day Adventists. They are to give the warnings to all peoples, nations, and tongues, telling them that God has a law which is as much above man-made laws as the heavens are above the earth. This law is to be proclaimed as the law of God's kingdom. The truth is not to languish upon our lips. Our words must not be words of peace and safety. Say not to the transgressors, It does not matter what you believe. Bear the testing message for this time. Say to the people as Christ said to Moses, "Six days may work be done; but the seventh is the Sabbath of rest, holy to the Lord; whosoever doeth any work in the Sabbath day, he shall surely be put to death" [Exodus 31:15].

A message of eternal importance is to be given to those nigh and those afar off. There is to be no smoothing down of the truth to gain the favor or applause of those in the world. We are not to form confederacies with those who, after the light has been given them by God's faithful servants, refuse to search the Scriptures to see whether these things are so. God's messengers are not to bind themselves up with unbelievers, feeling that in them is their strength. I present this before those who have had the light, but are fast losing their bearings. Let not God's ministers become bound up in any way with those who have had the truth presented to them, but have refused to receive it.

THE SABBATH IS INCLUSIVE

Through Christ Jew and Gentile may enter the spiritual fold. God will receive all who hold the beginning of their confidence firm unto the end. These are the only ones with whom He will fulfill the covenant mentioned in the thirty-first chapter of Exodus, where God declares that the Sabbath is a sign between Him and His people for a perpetual covenant [verses 16, 17].

Everywhere, in all ages of the world, God's words

have proved true. He that fears the Lord and works righteousness is accepted by Him. But when the pastors of the churches are ignorant of the Scriptures, when they are too indolent and self-satisfied to fear in regard to their understanding of the Scriptures, but oppose the truth, and are devoted to selfish interests, the flock of God is not fed. The people are not instructed in regard to present truth. The unfaithfulness of the watchmen is the chief cause of the backsliding of the people. When iniquity abounds in a nation, the watchmen are to be wide awake; for it is when iniquity abounds that the love of many waxes cold.

The message God gives through His servants will be scorned and derided by the unfaithful shepherds, who tread down with their feet the feed of the pastures, giving the flock as food that which they have defiled. "Woe to the pastors that destroy and scatter the sheep of my pastures," saith the Lord [Jeremiah 23:1]. No outward nearness to God, no acceptance of sacred work, will screen from the divine wrath those who trample under feet the law of Jehovah.

God "will render to every man according to his deeds: to them who by patient continuance in well doing seek for glory and honor and immortality, eternal life; but to them that are contentious, and do not obey the truth, but obey unrighteousness, indignation and wrath, tribulation and anguish, upon every son of man that doeth evil, of the Jew first, and also of the Gentile; but glory, honor, and peace, to every man that worketh good, to the Jew first, and also to the Gentile; for there is no respect of persons with God. For as many as have sinned without law shall also perish without law; and as many as have sinned in the law shall be judged by the law; for not the hearers of the law are just before God, but the doers of the law shall be justified" [Romans 2:6-13].

Seventh-day Adventists believe that **Ellen G. White** (1827-1915) exercised the biblical gift of prophecy during more than 70 years of public ministry. This excerpt was taken from Ellen G. White manuscript 35, 1900, in *Letters and Manuscripts*, vol. 15, p. 263.



BONAPARTE'S WONDER

LAEL CAESAR

The days are long, Lord of our life and light,

And sometimes nights seem slower than should be
—except that we have company.

The eyes that see

Vouch for the elegance of our endless, restless, east-west flights;
They see us sail across the north and think us agile.

You see us too: our sails, bogs, fens,

Ponds, marshes, conifers high, low

And near or far from water

Are never off Your monitor

—don't ask me how or why.

We fail and fall for finitude, but never fall without Your note
and knowing.

Your singular screen that spans

Sites where we prey and feed from,

The conifers that give us rest, nest, breed, and brood,

The places where we match, hatch, and disperse,

The lakes we swim, skim, bob, forage, float, and fly from

As it does the universe . . .

That is what we wonder at.

So too should they, so much more valued,

If they would believe,

Than Bonaparte's gull. ▀

Lael Caesar, former associate editor of *Adventist Review*, now retired, wrote this poem in 2021 in response to photos of Bonaparte's gulls our office received from Wayne and Steven Easley, who caught them in migratory flight near Hurdsfield, North Dakota.

Sherry and Gary

are ready to retire next year.

They need some advice on tax implications and ways to navigate this next stage in life. They are prepared to get more involved at church but want to ensure their bills are taken care of before they retire and give a significant donation to the children's programs.



To learn more about Sherry and Gary's next steps—
scan the QR code or visit willplan.org/SherryandGary



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THE SANCTUARY IN HISTORICAL PERSPECTIVE

*Exploring the development of
a core Adventist belief*

DENIS KAISER

As Seventh-day Adventists, we share the same Bible with other Christians, yet our interpretation of the biblical passages about the heavenly sanctuary sets us apart. How have others before us understood those passages? And how did we come to interpret them differently?

A SPIRITUALIZED VIEW

During the intertestamental period (the time between the Old and New Testaments) the notion of a timeless, immaterial heaven began to compete with the belief in a temporal-spatial heavenly sanctuary. By the early sixth century A.D. this belief had largely been replaced by the notion of a timeless and immaterial heaven, with a focus on earthly manifestations of the sanctuary, including their altars, priests, and sacrifices. The Protestant Reformers protested against ascribing sacred value to earthly entities and revived the focus on Jesus as our personal intercessor and high priest, yet they retained the spiritualized interpretation of the biblical passages about the heavenly sanctuary.

To understand how we came to interpret those passages differently, we need to delve into the history of Adventist thought. This includes examining how the Millerites, the disappointed Adventists, and the early Sabbatarian Adventists viewed the sanctuary. Their journey through intense study of Scripture led to our unique perspective on the heavenly sanctuary's role in the plan of salvation.

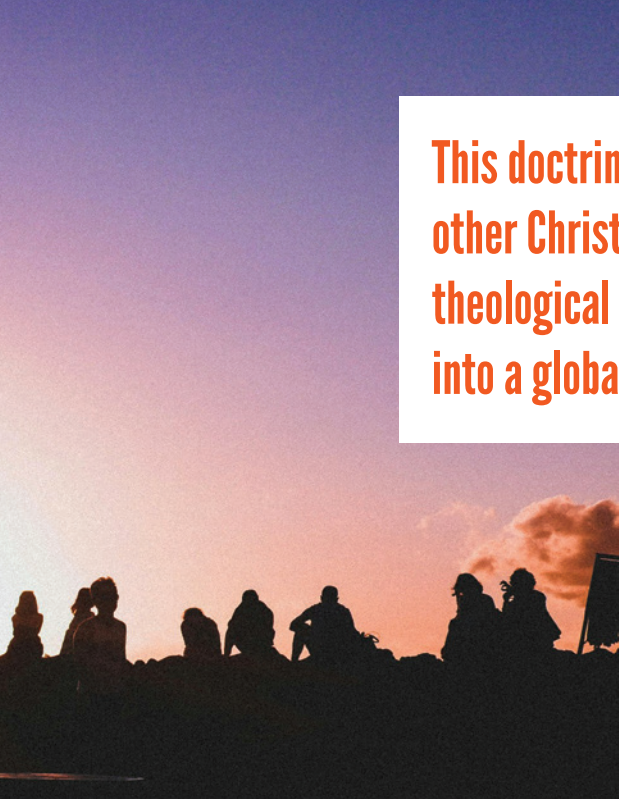
PARTIAL INSIGHT

The Millerite revival of the Second Great Awakening turned attention to Daniel 8, a passage rich in sanctuary language, yet it

did not break with the spiritualized perception of heaven. In 1818 the Baptist farmer William Miller read, "Unto two thousand and three hundred days; then shall the sanctuary be cleansed" (Dan. 8:14, KJV). To identify that sanctuary, he studied every biblical reference to "sanctuary," "temple," or "tabernacle." He identified seven sanctuaries: Jesus Christ, heaven, Judah, the Jerusalem temple, the Holy of Holies, the earth, and the saints.¹

Because Jesus and heaven were pure, Judah was no longer God's people, and the temple in Jerusalem was lying in ruins, Miller concluded that only the earth and the saints needed cleansing. He believed that this cleansing would occur at Christ's second coming, when the earth would be cleansed by fire and the saints would be transformed.²

Applying the year-day principle to the 2,300 days and starting the count from 457 B.C.,



This doctrine has not only set us apart from other Christians through its philosophical and theological paradigm shift, but also turned us into a global mission movement.

Miller concluded that they would end “about the year 1843,” predicting Christ’s second coming. As that year approached, he defined it more precisely as running from March 21, 1843, to March 21, 1844. Meanwhile, Samuel S. Snow proposed the coming of Christ in the fall of 1844. It was only after the “year 1843” had ended with the Millerites being disappointed that they became open to Snow’s proposal of a fall date.

Linking Miller’s interpretation of the Jewish festivals, Snow interpreted the cleansing of the sanctuary in Daniel 8:14 as the antitypical day of atonement (Lev. 16; 23:26-32), yet he still maintained the idea that this event would mark the return of Christ. The Millerites gradually united around proclaiming the return of Jesus on October 22, 1844, which, according to the calendar of the Karaite Jews, marked the Day of Atonement. Judging from the reactions of the public against the proclamation of the Second Coming, the Millerites concluded days before the expected event that the door of probation had closed (Matt. 25:10). Yet when Jesus did not return, the Millerites were deeply disappointed.

PARADIGM SHIFT

Whereas most believers retained the Millerite interpretation of Daniel 8:14 but endeavored to find new starting and ending dates for the 2,300

days, some Millerites realized they had missed the biblical teaching about the heavenly sanctuary. Neither Miller nor Snow had entertained the idea of a temporal-spatial sanctuary in heaven needing cleansing. The failure of Christ to return as expected pressed them to reevaluate their interpretation, laying the groundwork for a new understanding of the sanctuary in Daniel 8:14 and a revival of the belief in a sanctuary in heaven.

As Hiram Edson prayed for understanding on the morning after the disappointment, he felt impressed that “the sanctuary to be cleansed is in heaven.” Unable to grasp the meaning of that impression, he was driven to the Bible, where he found in Hebrews 9 that there was a sanctuary in heaven and that it required cleansing (Heb. 9:23). Studying the Bible with his friends O.R.L. Crosier and Franklin B. Hahn, he concluded that Christ entered the most holy place in heaven on October 22, 1844, starting a new phase of His ministry. They promoted their findings in the *Day-Dawn* and the *Day-Star* in March 1845 and February 1846, respectively.

Meanwhile, in February 1845 Ellen Harmon had a vision in which she saw that Jesus had entered the most holy place in the heavenly sanctuary and that believers should follow him there in faith. More important, she saw that He was still interceding for them, implying that the door of probation was not yet closed.³ Similarly, Emily C. Clemons encouraged believers in her paper, *Hope Within the Veil*, to enter the new covenant experience as Christ performed His extended atonement ministry.⁴

Unlike Snow, who presumed that the Day of Atonement had occurred on October 22, 1844, and that Christ had ended His priestly ministry, they believed this date marked the beginning of an extended Day of Atonement, with grace and mercy still available. The sanctuary doctrine not only explained the disappointment but also

The integrated sanctuary message made Sabbatarian Adventists aware of their duty to share the Sabbath more broadly to prepare people for the final events.

introduced a philosophical paradigm shift—returning the focus from heaven as a sanctuary to a sanctuary in heaven.⁵ This view of a temporal-spatial sanctuary aligned with their belief that the saints would receive immortality at Christ's second coming and be with Him in heaven in their bodies during the millennium.

INTEGRATIVE MESSAGE

This paradigm shift would have significant ramifications for the identity, message, and mission of the new fledgling movement.

In January 1847 Joseph Bates published a second edition of his tract *The Seventh Day Sabbath, A Perpetual Sign*, in which he linked the Sabbath with the heavenly sanctuary and the third angel's message. The revelation of the ark of the covenant in the heavenly sanctuary (Rev. 11:19) was followed by the depiction of a group of people, a remnant, who keep the commandments of God (Rev. 12:17) after the proclamation of the first and second angels' messages (Rev. 14:12), a fitting description of their recent experience. Bates believed Christ's move to the most holy place in October 1844 revealed the importance of the Ten Commandments, including the Sabbath.

In April 1847 Ellen White had a vision that confirmed the special relevance of the Sabbath commandment, thus supporting Bates' insights.⁶ Emphasizing the "tender love that God has for His people" in January 1849, she saw that Jesus, as our heavenly high priest, pleads His blood to delay the releasing of the winds of trouble until the sealing has been completed.⁷ While He had opened the door to the most holy place, some people were trying to keep that door shut and suppress the revived relevance of the Sabbath truth.⁸

Bates identified the Sabbath as the seal of God and argued that the 144,000 would be sealed with the Sabbath truth before the winds of trouble would be released (Rev. 7 and 13).⁹ Their discov-

eries gradually moved them beyond their early shut-door view.

The integrated sanctuary message made Sabbatarian Adventists aware of their duty to share the Sabbath more broadly to prepare people for the final events. Integrating these doctrinal elements gave them a prophetic identity, a coherent message, and an urgent mission that pushed them to the ends of the world.¹⁰

CONCLUSION

The discovery of the sanctuary doctrine has "opened to view a complete system of truth."¹¹ Many of our doctrines are directly or indirectly connected to the belief in a sanctuary in heaven, Christ's high-priestly ministry (Heb. 8), and the pre-Advent judgment in our favor (Dan. 7; 8). Instead of being a judgment to fear, the day of atonement judgment confirms God's justice and mercy based on Christ's atoning sacrifice, thus providing us with assurance of salvation. This doctrine has not only set us apart from other Christians through its philosophical and theological paradigm shift, but also turned us into a global mission movement. ■

¹ William Miller, *Letter to Joshua V. Himes, on the Cleansing of the Sanctuary* (Boston: J. V. Himes, 1842), pp. 4-14.

² *Ibid.*

³ Ellen G. White, *Early Writings* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1882, 1945), pp. 54-56.

⁴ See O.R.L. Crosier, "Letter From Bro. O.R.L. Crosier," *Day-Star*, Oct. 11, 1845, p. 50.

⁵ Ellen G. White, *The Spirit of Prophecy* (Battle Creek, Mich.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1884), vol. 4, pp. 268-270; Ellen G. Harmon, "Letter From Sister Harmon," *Day-Star*, Mar. 14, 1846; Ellen G. White letter 3, 1847, to Joseph Bates, July 13, 1847, in Ellen G. White, *Manuscript Releases* (Silver Spring, Md.: Ellen G. White Estate, 1990), vol. 5, pp. 95-98.

⁶ Ellen G. White to Joseph Bates, Apr. 7, 1847, published in *A Word to the "Little Flock,"* ed. James White (Brunswick, Maine: James White, 1847), p. 18.

⁷ Ellen G. White, "To Those Who Are Receiving the Seal of the Living God," broadside, Jan. 31, 1849, in *The Ellen G. White Letters and Manuscripts With Annotations* (Hagerstown, Md.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 2014), vol. 1, p. 150.

⁸ Ellen G. White, "Dear Brethren and Sisters," *Present Truth*, August 1849, p. 21.

⁹ Joseph Bates to Leonard and Elvira Hastings, Aug. 7, 1848; Joseph Bates, *A Seal of the Living God: A Hundred Forty-four Thousand of the Servants of God Being Sealed in 1849* (New Bedford, Mass.: Benjamin Lindsey, 1849).

¹⁰ George R. Knight, *William Miller and the Rise of Adventism* (Nampa, Idaho: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 2010), pp. 264-267, 284, 285.

¹¹ E. G. White, *The Spirit of Prophecy*, vol. 4, p. 268.

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LIVING YOUR LEGACY

*Impacting today
and shaping tomorrow*

Within the Bible lie stories that resonate with ageless wisdom, offering insights that go beyond their time and context. One such narrative unfolds in 2 Samuel 21:20, 21, where Jonathan, the nephew of King David, confronts a formidable giant—a six-fingered, six-toed descendant of Goliath. This encounter is far more than a mere clash of warriors; it's a profound illustration of how our actions can create a ripple effect, shaping our world and leaving a legacy for generations.

Jonathan's victory over Goliath's relative was not an isolated event. It was the result of Jonathan living a life of purpose. He voluntarily was shaped by the influence, legacy, and example of King David, his father's brother (verse 21). This account contains three insights on how we can build a legacy for now and the future.

First, to leave a powerful influence, live a life with purpose. This means making intentional choices that align with our highest values and principles. Every decision we make, every action we take, contributes to the legacy we are building—not just for the future, but for the present. Our influence begins with the people we interact with today—our family, friends, colleagues, and community.

Consider the story of Mother Teresa, who began her work with nothing more than a small group of volunteers in the slums of Calcutta. Her consistent acts of kindness, compassion, and dedication to the poorest of the poor seemed small in the moment, but they grew into a global legacy of service. In the same way, the seemingly small actions we take each day can create a ripple effect, build-

ing a legacy that far exceeds our immediate surroundings.

Second, prepare for the unexpected by choosing principles, always. Jonathan's act of bravery was the result of his diligence as a warrior who lived in preparation for such a moment. Similarly, we must recognize that each day offers opportunities to live out truth. We have the opportunity to intentionally create a ripple effect of positive influence. Seemingly small principled actions build up over time, contributing to a lasting effective legacy.

By mentoring, encouraging, and supporting family, friends, colleagues, even strangers, we pass on our values and experiences in a way that is influential and enduring. No encounter is too small or inconsequential. Legacy is intertwined with our experiences and the lives we touch with love, care, and truth.

Finally, live with the consciousness of living our legacy as well as leaving our legacy. Be mindful of how we are living now. The choices we make today are the building blocks of our lasting legacy. Are we living in a way that we would be proud to look back on? By living with the end in mind, we can ensure that our present actions are aligned with the legacy we want to leave.

Jonathan's victory over Goliath's relative is a compelling reminder: Legacy is not just about the future—it's about the choices we make today. By living with intention, influencing those around us, and nurturing relationships, we shape a legacy that echoes in both the present and the future. Every moment counts! Let's live with the end in mind and make our lives a testament to an enduring legacy. 🍀

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**PRACTICALLY
SPEAKING**
DELBERT W.
BAKER



**LEGACY IS
INTERTWINED WITH
OUR EXPERIENCES
AND THE LIVES WE
TOUCH WITH LOVE,
CARE, AND TRUTH.**



THE GOOD NEWS OF THE INVESTIGATIVE JUDGMENT

*Finding joy in
an unlikely
doctrine*

The three angels' messages of Revelation 14 present the pre-Advent investigative judgment as an integral part of the gospel: "Then I saw another angel flying in the midst of heaven, having the everlasting gospel [*euangelion*, "good news"] to preach to those who dwell on the earth . . . saying with a loud voice, 'Fear God and give glory to Him, for the hour of His judgment has come'" (Rev. 14:6, 7).

Is the biblical message of the end-time investigative judgment really assuring, good news? I have not always considered it good news. While growing up as a fourth-generation Seventh-day Adventist Christian, I used to shudder at the mention of divine judgment. Even as a young pastor, I avoided preaching about the judgment. Imagine then my surprise when I came across a number of prayers in the book of Psalms in which David prayed, "Judge me, O Lord!" (Ps. 7:8; 26:1; 35:24; 43:1). He seemed to be saying, in effect, "Hurry up, Lord! Send the judgment. Bring it on! Let my name come up. I can hardly wait!"

How could David pray such a prayer? Later in his life David acknowledged the heinousness of his own sin and the reality of the judgment (Ps. 51:3, 4). But he also grasped the message of righteousness by faith! He prayed, "Purge me with hyssop [the plant used to apply the blood of the Passover sacrifice upon the doorposts of the house (Ex. 12:22; Lev. 14:4-6; Num. 19:18)], and I shall be clean" (Ps. 51:7). In effect, he prayed, "Cleanse/cover me with the blood of the Lamb of God, my Substitute, and I shall have assurance of acceptance with You in the judgment!"

The Bible consistently upholds the seriousness of sin and the certainty of the judgment. But it also reveals that the judgment is good news! In fact, I have found at least seven scriptural reasons for joyous assurance in the judgment.¹

CHRIST IS OUR SUBSTITUTE

As just mentioned with the testimony of David, the Bible teaches that the Lamb of God our Substitute has been accepted in our place. When we receive Christ, we are covered with the robe of His righteousness (Isa. 61:10; Zech. 3:4; cf. Gen. 3:21). We are acquitted, pardoned, and cleansed. We are no longer "anxious about what Christ and God think of us, but about what God thinks of Christ, our Substitute."² What does God the Father think of Christ our Substitute? He is accepted! Thus, when we are in Christ, we may know that we are "accepted in the Beloved" (Eph. 1:6).

When I was a young pastor, the beauty and simplicity of the gospel began to dawn before my eyes. Through a chain of marvelous providential influences, the sublime promises jumped out at me from Scripture, and I dared to claim them for myself: "Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me *has* everlasting life" (John 6:47). "These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may *know* that you *have* eternal life" (1 John 5:13).

Since that experiential introduction to gospel assurance, the beauty of righteousness by faith has grown ever more precious. Christ is my substitute, who has paid the penalty for my sins with His blood. What assuring good news! But there is more!

CHRIST IS OUR LAWYER/ADVOCATE

In the judgment Christ is also our advocate, our lawyer. “And if anyone sins, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous” (1 John 2:1). Our heavenly Advocate has never lost a case that has been committed to Him (John 18:9). A courtroom loses its fear for the one being tried if the lawyer can guarantee that he has never lost and will never lose a case committed to his hands. This is what Jesus promises, based upon His sacrifice on our behalf.

In the heavenly court Christ eloquently and persuasively pleads our case based upon His blood. In the judgment “Jesus pleads in [His followers’] behalf His wounded hands, His bruised body; and He declares to all who would follow Him: ‘My grace is sufficient for thee.’ 2 Corinthians 12:9”³

For those in Christ, the heavenly courtroom is a friendly place. Our heavenly Lawyer stands beside them with His arm around them, as it were; He “does not excuse their sins, but shows their penitence and faith, and, claiming for them forgiveness, He lifts His wounded hands before the Father and the holy angels, saying: I know them by name. I have graven them on the palms of My hands [citing Isaiah 49:16]”⁴

Christ is my lawyer, who has never lost a case that has been committed to Him. What assuring good news! But there is more!

CHRIST IS THE STAR WITNESS ON OUR BEHALF!

To the church at Laodicea (a name that means “people of the judgment”), representing the people who are living during the time of the pre-advent judgment, Christ reveals Himself as the “Faithful and True Witness” (Rev. 3:14). Not only does He warn the Laodicean people of their true spiritual condition; but for those who repent of their sins and open the door of their heart for Him to come in and dine with them, He also testifies on their behalf in the heavenly court. As their Star Witness, He brings evidence to the heavenly jury in support of His people that silences the false accusations of the adversary.

Christ is my Star Witness in the heavenly court. That is assuring good news. But there is more!

CHRIST IS OUR JUDGE!

While still on earth, Jesus announced, “For the Father judges no one, but has committed all judgment to the Son” (John 5:22). Our Elder Brother, our

Best Friend, is the Judge! This Judge has never made a mistake, and He is on our side! He is not a stern, harsh magistrate seeking to condemn all He can, but a loving, gracious God seeking to save all He can.

The multiple functions of a single individual in the judgment may seem strange to our modern Western legal system, but it is entirely in keeping with the biblical concept of administering justice. At the city gates the same elder(s) could convene the judicial proceedings, argue as an advocate, give testimony, and render the verdict. At the Israelite sanctuary the priest not only did all of this (Deut. 17:8-13) but also bore the penalty of the sins (Lev. 10:17).

With Christ as our substitute and surety, our advocate and mediator, our witness and friend and judge, what more assuring news can we ask for? What we have described thus far is the *basis* of our acceptance in the judgment, justification by faith.⁵ But there is more!

CHRIST IS OUR PURIFIER

Jesus does not wish to leave us wallowing in our sins. In the context of eschatological judgment, Ezekiel records God’s promise of cleansing for His people:

“Then I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean; I will cleanse you from all your filthiness and from all your idols. I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will take the heart of stone out of your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. I will put My Spirit within you and cause you to walk in My statutes, and you will keep My judgments and do them” (Eze. 36:25-27).

God Himself assumes ultimate responsibility for the cleansing and the obedience of His people. What assuring good news! We are saved by blood, by grace, alone, but the efficacy of the blood becomes manifest to all by its holy fruit in the lives of God’s people (see especially Phil. 1:6, 9-11).

Assurance and judgment—these two concepts meet and take on ultimate meaning in the atypical day of atonement. This is assuring good news indeed. But there is more!

CHRIST IS OUR VINDICATOR

When we belong to Christ, in the judgment the tables are turned. No longer do we stand accused as a defendant, for Christ has paid the full price for our acquittal. Now we become the plaintiff, calling for vindication against the false charges of

Satan. Like David, we can pray, “Judge [“vindicate” (ESV)] me, O Lord my God, according to Your righteousness” (Ps. 35:24).

The outcome of the eschatological judgment is certain. It is “in favor of the saints of the Most High” (Dan. 7:22). The judgment brings vindication for God’s people, who have been falsely accused by Satan (Rev. 12:10). Throughout Scripture the primary use of judgment terminology refers to God’s work of justification, salvation, deliverance, and vindication of His people.⁵

Vindication of the saints in the judgment! What assuring good news. But there is more! The best news of the judgment is saved for last. And it is ultimately not about us, but about God Himself.

THE VINDICATION OF GOD

The investigative judgment is not conducted to reveal to God who are His and who are not. He who is omniscient knows who are His (Isa. 46:9, 10; John 10:4, 14, 27; 2 Tim. 2:19; Heb. 4:13). Rather, at the end of the great controversy all the universe will have opportunity to witness and attest to the wisdom, justice, and truthfulness of God’s dealings with humankind. Satan’s charges against God will be shown to be false.

All humanity will either become fully “established, strengthened, and settled” into the truth as it is in Jesus (see 1 Peter 5:10) and be sealed (Rev. 7:2-8), or become fully established, strengthened, and settled into the lie (2 Thess. 2:11) and receive the mark of the beast (Rev. 13:16, 17; 14:11). Then God can point to the ultimate result of the two ways—the ways of God and the ways of Satan—and the whole universe will see the justice and truth of God’s way and the deceitfulness and lie of Satan’s way.

At the grand climax to the great controversy there will be a time of great rejoicing—and the good news will be about God’s vindication in the judgment. The redeemed will sing the song of Moses and of the Lamb: “Great and marvelous are Your works, Lord God Almighty! Just and true are Your ways, O King of the saints!” (Rev. 15:3).

By means of the entire process of the end-time divine judgment, God fully vindicates His character of love, and thus the universe will be rendered eternally secure. Assurance in the judgment will give way to assurance for eternity! What glorious good news! ▀

¹ In what follows I freely draw from material from my book *A Song for the Sanctuary: Experiencing God’s Presence in Shadow and Reality* (Silver Spring, Md.: Biblical Research Institute, Review and Herald Academic, 2022), chap. 27.

² Ellen G. White, *Selected Messages* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1958, 1980), book 2, pp. 32, 33.

³ Ellen G. White, *The Great Controversy* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1911), p. 489.

⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 484.

⁵ For a full treatment of the biblical doctrine of justification by faith, with emphasis on the Old Testament foundations, see Richard M. Davidson, “How Shall a Person Stand Before God? What Is the Meaning of Justification?” in *God’s Character and the Last Generation*, ed. Jiří Moskala and John C. Peckham (Nampa, Idaho: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 2018), pp. 58-102.

⁶ See Davidson, *Song for the Sanctuary*, pp. 431-441.

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The best
news of the
judgment
is saved for
last. And it
is ultimately
not about us,
but about
God Himself.

A DIVINE APPOINTMENT





Why and how 1844 still matters

ROY E. GANE

Did you ever miss an important event because you didn't know when it was going to happen? Were you supposed to have a part in the event? Was the appointment important for your life and that of others?

People need to know about their appointments, including when they are, why they are important, and what should be done when the time arrives. This is especially true of appointments with God.

DAY OF ATONEMENT APPOINTMENT

For example, the Lord told the Israelites when to show loyalty to Him by fasting, etc., and resting from work on the Day of Atonement (Lev. 16:29, 31; 23:26-32): "On the ninth day of the month beginning at evening, from evening to evening shall you keep your Sabbath" (Lev. 23:32, ESV). "Evening" meant sunset, so this was a precise time.

Israelites who showed their loyalty would receive moral purification (Lev. 16:30), confirming their relationship with God. But the Lord would punish anyone who failed to obey His instructions (Lev. 23:29, 30). So the Day of Atonement was Israel's judgment day, an appointment that a loyal person would not want to miss!

The Israelites had to depend on what God told them about the time of their appointment with Him. They could not see their high priest as he ritually/symbolically purified the areas inside the tabernacle with sacrificial blood (Lev. 16:14-17). Similarly, the Jews of Susa could not see Queen Esther go before the king to save their lives, but she told them to fast where they were (Esther 4:16).

The Day of Atonement was a uniquely important appointment. Only on this day was the sanctuary cleansed from the impurities and sins of all Israelites that had affected it throughout the previous year (Lev. 16:16-20, 33). The sanctuary was God's headquarters, representing His administration, character, and reputation. Purifying His sanctuary by special sacrifices demonstrated that the Lord was right in affirming those among His professed people who were loyal and in condemning the disloyal.

The sacrifices of the Day of Atonement pointed to the gospel/good news of salvation through the one sacrifice of Jesus Christ (Heb. 9:26). Because of His sacrifice, God is just when He justifies those who believe in Jesus (Rom. 3:26) and when He condemns those who reject this free mercy. In both cases God shows His justice and mercy, the two sides of His character of love (Ex. 34:6, 7; 1 John 4:8, 16).¹

END-TIME JUDGMENT APPOINTMENT

Revelation, the last book in the Bible, prophesies a judgment event with a gospel message that is greater than the Israelite Day of Atonement because it is for the whole world:

"Then I [John] saw another angel flying directly overhead, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on earth, to every nation and

tribe and language and people. And he said with a loud voice, 'Fear God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come, and worship him who made heaven and earth, the sea and the springs of water' " (Rev. 14:6, 7, ESV).

The Greek word translated "angel" means "messenger." Who is the messenger to whom Jesus gave the commission to share His gospel? It is His followers (Matt. 28:19, 20). So all true Christians, God's "royal priesthood" (1 Peter 2:9), are to give a special proclamation of the gospel shortly before Christ's second coming to earth (Rev. 14:14-20). They are to call everyone to give allegiance to their Creator. The message is an urgent last warning and appeal because "the hour of His judgment has come" (verse 7). There is little time left for anyone to decide for God and be saved.

When does this judgment begin? His people need to know this in order to appeal effectively to others. But Revelation 14 doesn't further identify the pre-Advent judgment or when it takes place. Revelation assumes that we can know about the event from earlier in the Bible. It is the visions of Daniel that describe the judgment and its timing.

Daniel 7:9-14 portrays the judgment in heaven, witnessed by millions of beings. It comes after a period of domination by a power symbolized as a "little horn," which defies God and persecutes His faithful followers (verses 8, 20, 21, 24, 25). At the time of the judgment in a final phase of history, "one like a son of man" (Christ) comes to "the Ancient of Days" (God the Father) in order to receive the kingdom of this world for Himself and His loyal people (see also verses 26, 27).

In Daniel 8, what brings an end to the domination by the "horn" is the justifying of God's sanctuary (verse 14). So this event is the equivalent of the judgment in Daniel 7. Through the judgment God's sanctuary is justified/vindicated. In other words, it is legally "cleansed." This is the worldwide end-time equivalent of the Israelite Day of Atonement, when judgment showed that God was right, as ritually represented by the cleansing of His sanctuary.

TIMING OF THE END-TIME JUDGMENT

Daniel 8:14 identifies the time that the justifying of God's sanctuary, which corresponds to the heavenly judgment, begins: "Unto 2,300 evening(s) morning(s), then the sanctuary will be justified" (translation by Roy E. Gane). The end of the 2,300

evening(s) morning(s) can be calculated quite simply in seven steps from information supplied by Daniel 8 and 9.²

Step 1: The "2,300 evening(s) morning(s)" = "days" are much longer than literal days because this period covers history prophesied in Daniel's vision from the time of Medo-Persian domination (Dan. 8:3, 20) through a sequence of major world empires.

Step 2: According to Daniel 9 Gabriel came to Daniel to explain more about the "vision" (verse 23), which must be the one in Daniel 8, because there is no vision in Daniel 9. This explanation revealed another time period: "seventy weeks" (Dan. 9:24-27).

Step 3: The "seventy weeks" began in 457 B.C., when Daniel 9:25 was fulfilled. At that time the "word"/decree from the Persian king Artaxerxes I went out to the Jewish people to restore Jerusalem to their civil control (Ezra 7, especially verses 25, 26). As a result, they started rebuilding the city (Ezra 4:11-16).

Step 4: The "seventy weeks" are weeks of years: 490 years. They cannot be weeks of days, because too much was to happen during this period. It began in 457 B.C. and would include the coming of the Messiah (Dan. 9:25-27).

Step 5: The 490 years are the first segment of the "2,300 days." The 490 years are "cut off" (and so "determined") for the Jewish people (Dan. 9:24). That is, they are cut off from a longer period, which must be the "2,300 days." They are cut off from the first part of the "2,300" days to answer Daniel's concerns about his people, Jerusalem, and its temple (verses 2-20). Therefore, the "2,300 days" began at the same time as the 490 years: 457 B.C.

Step 6: The "2,300 days" represent 2,300 years because they include the 490 years.

Step 7: The 2,300 years end in A.D. 1844. Going forward 2,300 years from 457 B.C. extends to A.D. 1844, taking into account that there was no zero year (only 1 B.C. immediately followed by A.D. 1). On a calculator, 2,300 minus 457 = 1843 + 1 = 1844.

NOW, THAT'S 1844 MADE SIMPLER!

Now we know that the end-time judgment prophesied in Daniel 7 and 8 and in Revelation 14:7 "has come" as of 1844. It is the Great Appointment (not Disappointment). So God's sanctuary that is cleansed through the judgment is His sanctuary in heaven, where the divine Christ now ministers as

our high priest (Heb. 7-9). Nobody can see what Christ is doing during this phase of salvation, just as the Israelites could not see what their high priest was doing inside the tabernacle. Adventists can rely only on the fulfillment of the prophetic time period.

GOD'S INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE JUDGMENT TIME

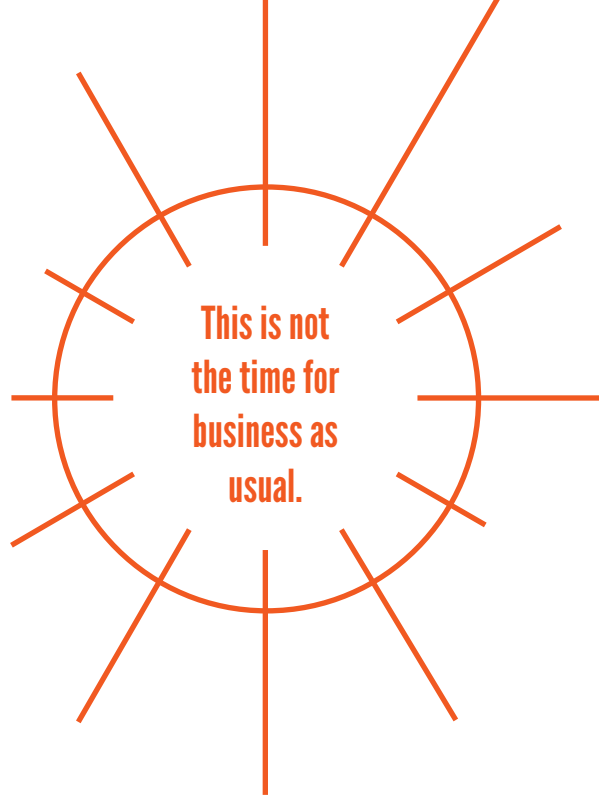
God's instructions for His people during the time when His judgment "has come" are in the three messages recorded in Revelation 14:6-12. As His messengers, we are to accept, live, and proclaim these messages of warning and hope that reveal God's justice and mercy. Even the terrible warning in the third message (verses 9-11) shows mercy and hope because it is not a condemnation, but a conditional warning intended to keep people from suffering the horrible fate that it describes.

At the end of the third message and concluding all three messages are the words: "Here is the patience of the saints; here are those who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus" (verse 12). Just as the ancient Israelites on their Day of Atonement were to (1) keep sabbath and (2) humble themselves through self-denial, God's end-time people are to do two things. First, they are to keep the commandments of God, including the seventh-day Sabbath, which is a sign that the Lord makes His people holy (Ex. 31:13). Second, they are to keep the faith of Jesus, who "humbled Himself" (Phil. 2:8). The commandments of God and Jesus' faith are the law and the gospel blended in transformed human lives. They are "faith working through love" (Gal. 5:6) to demonstrate God's character of love.

God's commandments are love (Matt. 22:37-40), and Jesus humbled Himself because God loves the world (John 3:16). So the message during the judgment that began in 1844 is about God's love. This echoes the end of the Old Testament, which appeals to God's people to remember the law (of love) that He gave to Moses, and predicts an "Elijah" who would facilitate relational reconciliation (of love) before "the great and awesome day of the Lord" (Mal. 4:4-6, ESV). The end-time message of love is empowered by the Holy Spirit (Joel 2:28, 29), who pours God's love into the hearts (Rom. 5:5) of those who have been "justified by faith" (verse 1).

CONCLUSION

The year 1844 was a long time ago, but the judgment is continuing now. Figuring out when it began



is not too complicated. It is really happening, even though we can't see it. It is very important for us and others, and we have a special role.

The appeal to "fear God and give glory to Him" and worship the Creator (Rev. 14:7) has been appropriate throughout human history. But now that "the hour of His judgment has come" (verse 7), beginning in 1844, the call is especially urgent because Jesus can come again anytime when the good news of God's love shown through Christ has gone viral as a witness to all nations (Matt. 24:14). The opportunity for people to make decisions is almost over. This is not the time for business as usual.

God can save only those who totally commit in this life to live by His principles of love forever by free choice. How many people around us have made that commitment? If they have not, do we care about them enough to show them what God has revealed in the Bible so that they too can enjoy eternal life, peace, and happiness? 📌

¹ For more information, see Roy E. Gane, *The Sanctuary and Salvation: The Practical Significance of Christ's Sacrifice and Priesthood* (Madrid, Spain: Editorial Safeliz, 2019), pp. 177-222.

² For more information and answers to objections, see Roy E. Gane, *Who's Afraid of the Judgment? The Good News About Christ's Work in the Heavenly Sanctuary* (Nampa, Idaho: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 2006), pp. 59-86.

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WHEN A MASTER PLAYS A FLAWED PIANO

Expect a miraculously phenomenal experience.

On January 24, 1975, Keith Jarrett went to Cologne to give a concert. He was in poor physical shape. Nevertheless, he wanted to give the concert. The 1300 people who had bought tickets were not to be disappointed.

In preparation for the concert, the world-renowned jazz pianist asked for a very special instrument. He wanted a Bösendorfer Model 290 Imperial. The biggest and best of the manufacturer's grand pianos.

When he arrived on stage at the Cologne Opera House and saw the instrument standing there, his jaw dropped. There was indeed a Bösendorfer grand piano there, but it was a small practice grand piano the stagehands had wheeled out because of a misunderstanding.

The jazz virtuoso looked at the small instrument, which was obviously not in good condition. Very skeptically Jarrett sat down at the piano to feel how the instrument worked and hear how it sounded. The disappointment was enormous.

The piano was not properly tuned. The pedals didn't work properly. The brightest notes were tinny, and the bass was light and thin. The baby grand piano really wasn't an instrument to show what a pianist was capable of.

But there was far too little time to get another instrument in place, and a piano tuner would have needed several hours to get the piano in good shape.

Jarrett wanted to cancel the entire concert, but the 17-year-old concert organizer begged him to go ahead with the performance despite the miserable

**ARNE-KRISTIAN
ANDERSEN**

piano. After careful consideration, Jarrett agreed, both because his record company was going to make a live recording and the recording equipment was set up, and because he didn't want to let the audience down.

From the very first note the audience knew they were in for a magical evening. Jarrett started with improvisations, and as he played, his playing evolved to undulate between simplicity and complexity. When the concert ended, a deafening applause broke out in the packed opera house. The album recorded that night became the best-selling jazz album by a single person. When referring to this event from January 24, 1975, it is simply called the "Cologne Concert."

GOD AND THE FLAWED INSTRUMENT

"Dream team" is the phrase used when we put together a team consisting of optimal players. In the dream team we find the perfect balance between the team members' abilities and personality. Of course, we also want our churches to be the dream team.

The perfect church team, however, is a utopia.

The kingdom of God is a different kingdom. The power of the Holy Spirit is not primarily manifested in strength and power. The Spirit's power is often seen as you scratch your head in bewilderment, not knowing what to do with the resources you have. It shows up in church members whose lives are flawed. People who can barely articulate their faith might turn out to be evangelists, and in a powerful way.

I marvel at the way God is playing the instrument we call church. An instrument that often turns out to have out-of-tune strings, unbalanced tonality, and a tinny sound.

GOD USES HOPELESS SITUATIONS FOR SOMETHING GREAT

In the book *Challenges of Christian Leadership* John Stott recounts an experience from 1958 during which he led an evangelistic campaign for university students in Sydney, Australia. The day before the last meeting of the series, Stott lost his voice. He still had to preach. Before he entered the stage, he had some students read the passage in 2 Corinthians 12 where Paul speaks about the "thorn in the flesh" and concludes like this:

"And [the Lord] said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness.' Therefore most gladly I will rather boast in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me" (2 Cor. 12:9).

Stott describes what happened: "We prayed that the thorn in the flesh might be taken away from me, and if I remember rightly they laid hands on me with prayer. But we went on to pray that if it pleased God to keep me in weakness, I would rejoice in my infirmities in order that the power of Christ might rest upon me, because when I am weak I am strong."¹

Stott continues: "I remember that I had to get within one inch of the microphone. I croaked the gospel. I was unable to use any inflections of voice, was unable to express personality. I was just a croak in a monotone, and all the time we were crying to God that His power would be demonstrated in human weakness."²

Despite the physical challenges Stott was struggling with, the response to his appeal to accept Christ was greater than any of the preceding nights.

"Since 1958 I've been back to Australia about 10 times, and on every occasion somebody has come up to me and said, 'Do you remember that night of preaching in the university hall when you'd lost your voice?' and I'd say, 'How could I ever forget it?' And the person responded, 'I was converted that night.'"³

We would have liked to be a Bösendorfer Model 290 Imperial. Instead, on the stage in front of us, there is a small and worn practice piano from a dusty basement. We see it throughout the Bible, and we see it in our own lives: God's way of working isn't quite what we expect. And while we wonder if this will work, the Pianist gets ready to play supernatural notes. Time for a concert.⁴ 🦋

¹ John Stott, *Problems of Christian Leadership* (Downers Grove, Ill.: InterVarsity Press, 2014), pp. 24, 25.

² *Ibid.*, p. 25.

³ *Ibid.*

⁴ The original version of this story was published on the Norwegian Union Conference website: <https://www.adventist.no/perspektiv/nar-det-elendige-pianoet-blir-brukt-av-en-mester/>.

Arne-Kristian Andersen serves as a pastor in Bergen, Norway.

**I marvel at
the way God
is playing the
instrument we
call church.**

THE END OF AN ERA

*Calm and predictable
gave way to questions
and debate.*

MERLE POIRIER

Editor Kenneth H. Wood was one half of a dynamic duo. His wife, Miriam, was a prolific author whose wit, words, and wisdom could hold any reader or audience spellbound. The Woods were active in ministry together, and during his time at the *Review* it was no different.

When Wood became assistant editor, he thought of a way to include Miriam in his work. He suggested she write a column under the pseudonym “Anne Observer,” because of her interesting way of relating to people.¹ He remembers her writing under this moniker for some time before eventually becoming a regular columnist under F. D. Nichol, writing for young people. Later she also wrote Dear Miriam, one of the most popular columns in the *Review*’s history under editor William G. Johnsson.

Perhaps because of Miriam’s gifts or simply because he was aware of the current women’s movement, in 1975 he wrote an editorial, “Avoid ‘Linguistic Sexisms,’” on a statement by editors of another non-Adventist publication related to gender-inclusive language, but ending on a pro-active but balanced position.

“It is important for us to keep in step with the times. It is important for us to avoid giving unnecessary offense to any group. But let us not become so relevant that we become irrelevant. In our efforts to do justice to the feminist movement or any other contemporary movement, let us not do injustice to the Word of God.”²

Jocelyn Fay joined the *Review* staff in 1973 as an editorial secretary. She was followed soon after that by Aileen Andres (Sox) a year later. In 1977 Wood wrote to K. W. Tilghman, general manager of the *Review* and Herald Publishing Association (RHPA), requesting a promotion for Fay. “This change of status is one of title rather than of responsibilities,” Wood



Two covers that demonstrate the issues the *Review* was willing to tackle. Women’s ordination on March 7, 1985 and smoking on August 29, 1991.



Miriam Wood



Jocelyn Fay



Aileen Andres Sox

wrote. "She is already carrying the responsibilities normally associated with the work of assistant editor. . . . In one respect the appointment of Jocey as an assistant editor would be a first. So far as I know, no woman has ever before served on the *Review* staff as assistant editor."³

Aileen writes of her memory interviewing for her position. "He promised that if I learned editorial work, he'd promote me, and he was faithful to his word. I started as a secretary and left 11 years later as an assistant editor."⁴ Fay and Sox went on to become editors in their own right for other publications, but they paved the way for many women who later served as assistant editors of the *Review*, including Sikhululekile Daco, who now serves as the first female associate editor.

OFFICIAL VOICE?

One frequent debate that emerged sometime in the sixties was on whether the voice of the *Review* could be considered "official." In light of the swirling controversies that continued to assault the church in the 1970s and early eighties, it became a recurrent question to whichever editor was serving. A General Conference (GC) action in 1961 changed "General Church Paper of the Seventh-day Adventists" to "Official Organ of the Seventh-day Adventist Church."⁵ By 1967 Wood had changed it back to "General Church Paper of the Seventh-day Adventists."⁶ This became important because of the many opinions not only outside the church, but inside the leadership as well. "In spite of all of our disclaimers about its being an official organ, throughout its history the *Review* has been the 'unofficial' official voice of the church," Wood told Ron Graybill in an interview. "I would say this, that while the editors have complete freedom to publish whatever they feel is in the best interest of the church, they try as nearly as possible to reflect the theological positions of the church and to be constructive. . . . In a political climate like we live in today, church leaders need to be able to disassociate themselves from positions in the magazine that they do not agree with, or that have not been officially voted."⁷

The political climate was a reference to the strong and sometimes opposing positions taken sometimes by leaders within the General Conference, the pastoral ministry, and the laity. Wood took to vetting his editorials with GC leadership

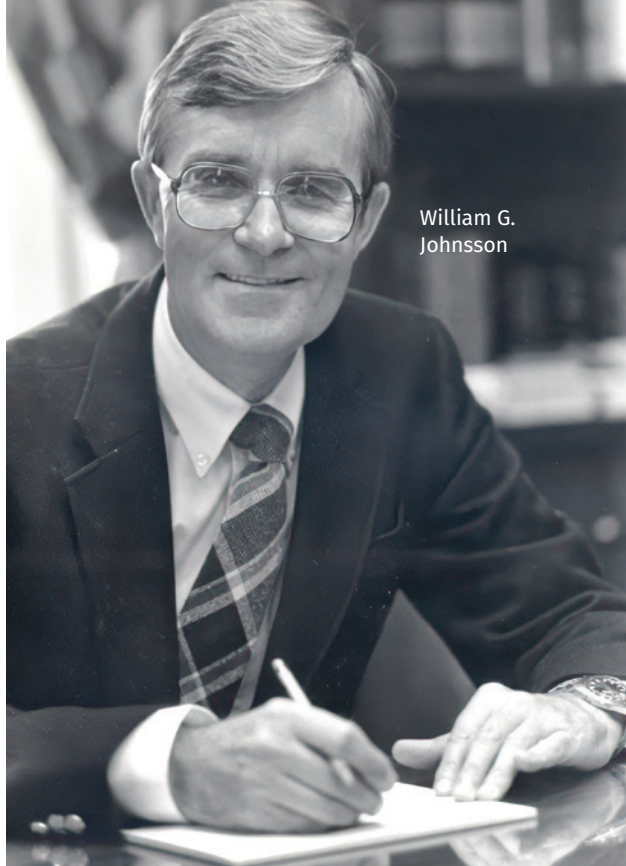
Johnsson brought much to the office that hopefully would assuage those who felt the *Review* to be simply a “mouthpiece” of GC leadership.

as a precaution. “In those days when I was editor of the *Review*, we tried to make the editorials represent the view of the church, even running the manuscripts past the vice presidents of the GC or the president where we thought that it was important to be representing the church.”⁸ As an example he related a situation in which he wrote one editorial that one vice president vehemently opposed and threatened to oppose the *Review* publicly at camp meetings if it was published. But feeling generally supported, Wood published it anyway.⁹

Another editorial was particularly controversial for Wood, and even years later he was asked about its implications. Entitled “Colleges in Trouble,” Wood related the views on the integrity and vision of Christian colleges by a non-Adventist author. He then went on to extend this same question to Adventist colleges. Referencing a strong Ellen White quote concerning Battle Creek College, he concluded his editorial in this way: “Of one thing we are certain: the church as a whole will back its educators in making Seventh-day Adventist schools truly Seventh-day Adventist, with all that that embodies by way of doctrinal purity, idealism, and excellence.”¹⁰ In the same issue the *Review* published a revised version of the Fundamental Beliefs (at that time totaling 27), with an editorial note that there was a growing need among members and workers that Adventist beliefs needed clarity.¹¹

A NEW ASSOCIATE

Perhaps in response to the many attacks being made on the *Review* editorial office, a decision was made to invite William G. Johnsson to the position of associate editor. He initially turned it down, but



William G.
Johnsson

REVIEW AND HERALD PUBLISHING ASSOCIATION

later accepted. Johnsson brought much to the office that hopefully would assuage those who felt the *Review* to be simply a “mouthpiece” of GC leadership. Better known as Bill, he was a New Testament scholar, authority on Hebrews (including the sanctuary doctrine), associate dean of the Seventh-day Adventist Theological Seminary, an Australian, and a well-known friend to those on the West Coast, where some of the opposition could be found. He joined the staff in September 1980.

Johnsson's first assignment even before coming to the *Review* office was to participate in the Glacier View meetings on Christ's role in the heavenly sanctuary. This was a strategic move on Wood's part: “Our report of the Glacier View meetings couldn't have been more accurate,” he wrote. “Our associate editor William Johnsson had just joined the *Review* staff. Glacier View was his first reporting assignment. I asked him, as a man not yet involved with the theological thrust of the magazine, to do an objective job of reporting, which he did.”¹²

AN IMPORTANT MOVE

The RHPA made a momentous decision to build a large printing plant in Hagerstown, Maryland.

Located about 70 miles from the GC, it would be the first time the two institutions were not side by side. Wood described the relationship as “if they (the GC) sneezed, we caught colds.”¹³ But it initiated a discussion as to whether the editors should be so far away from GC leadership. The suggestion was that close proximity allowed the editors to be more in touch with decisions. It would also have involved considerable travel to attend meetings that were held each week.

Both Wood and Johnsson held similar views—that staying with the GC was the better plan. But to stay meant that the *Review* would move under the auspices of the General Conference and away from the publishing house where it had always resided. “In many ways, it [being located at RHPA] was better than it is now because it was owned by the publishing house, and a good magazine needs to have independence,” Wood said reflectively. “If it is to have clout, it needs to have a strong subscription base. You see, when we had 110,000 subscribers, we could say things that even administration might not like. . . . I prized the independence we had. . . . I [could] call for accountability. They did not like . . . to have somebody else exerting influence. But at that time, the *Review* was capable of doing that.”¹⁴

“The *Review* editors were employed by the publishing house, with the church paper held in high esteem by church members as a vehicle loyal to the church but maintaining a respectful independence from the GC leadership,” wrote Johnsson.¹⁵ According to Johnsson, the subject was strongly debated at the 1982 Spring Meeting, with many arguing that “to separate the editors from RHPA could lead to the paper losing its prophetic voice. . . . When the issue was put to a vote, the floor was divided, with the majority favoring the D.C. location.”¹⁶ While perhaps not perceived so at the time other than by a few lone voices, this decision has proven to be probably one of the most impactful in the *Review*’s history.

During that same meeting it was announced that Kenneth Wood would retire at the time of the 1982 Annual Council. Bill Johnsson was nominated and voted as editor in chief to “carry the entire responsibility of this position after the 1982 Annual Council.”¹⁷ William G. Johnsson’s name first appeared as editor on December 2, 1982.

“I am just thankful in the 27 years that I was

involved with the *Review*, I didn’t disgrace it,” said Kenneth Wood. “I felt that during that period that the church paper was and should be one of the most stabilizing influences in the denomination. . . . It was a time in which the *Review* editor really needed to stand rigidly for something, and you don’t want to be standing for the wrong thing, because you can be misquoted and misunderstood.”¹⁸

While there may have been a change in editors, the conflict did not dissipate. “The decade of the eighties was the most turbulent and difficult in my experience,” wrote Bill Johnsson. “During the first half, the church was wracked by forces that seemed ready to tear it apart. For many, the ‘in’ thing was to put down the church, its standards, its leaders, Ellen White. It was as though the spirit of the 1960s that convulsed American society had sprung up twenty years later among Seventh-day Adventists. At the *Adventist Review*, we were in the eye of the storm.”¹⁹

According to Johnsson, the church, including the *Review*, would never return to its “halcyon days.” The *Review*, now housed within the General Conference, under a new board led by the GC president, amid unpredictable and turbulent times, was entering a new era.²⁰ 📌

¹ Oral History, Part 2, Kenneth Wood With Michael Campbell and James Nix, James R. Nix Adventist Heritage Collection, Ellen G. White Estate, Oct. 13, 2005, p. 10.

² *Review and Herald*, Jan. 30, 1975, p. 2.

³ K. H. Wood to K. W. Tilghman, Sept. 14, 1977.

⁴ *Adventist Review*, July 2024, p. 42.

⁵ Spring Meeting Minutes, Apr. 4, 1961, p. 890.

⁶ *Review and Herald*, Sept. 7, 1967, p. 1.

⁷ *Spectrum*, “Kenneth Wood on the State of the Church,” Dec. 1982, p. 20.

⁸ Oral History, Part 1, Kenneth Wood With Michael Campbell and James Nix, James R. Nix Adventist Heritage Collection, Ellen G. White Estate, Apr. 12, 2005, p. 43.

⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 44.

¹⁰ “Colleges in Trouble,” *Adventist Review*, Feb. 21, 1980, p. 3.

¹¹ *Adventist Review*, Feb. 21, 1980, p. 8.

¹² “Interview With Kenneth H. Wood,” *Insight*, June 9, 1989, p. 5.

¹³ Oral History, Part 2, Kenneth Wood With Michael Campbell and James Nix, p. 12.

¹⁴ Oral History, Part 1, Kenneth Wood With Michael Campbell and James Nix, p. 54.

¹⁵ Email to Merle Poirier from William G. Johnsson, Oct. 9, 2022.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*

¹⁷ Spring Meeting Minutes, Apr. 8, 1982, p. 87.

¹⁸ Oral History, Part 2, Kenneth Wood With Michael Campbell and James Nix, p. 12.

¹⁹ William G. Johnsson, *The Fragmenting of Adventism* (Boise, Idaho: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1995), p. 7.

²⁰ *Ibid.*

Merle Poirier is the operations manager for *Adventist Review*.

Our Guiding Star

*Faith in Jesus, the incarnate God,
is the path of salvation.*

WILLIAM G. JOHNSON

This month features excerpts from an article in the February 11, 1999, issue of the Adventist Review, in which editor William G. Johnson highlights the Incarnation and the crucial significance of faith in Jesus as God in the flesh and how Jesus is the center of the Adventist faith.

Nearly 2,000 years ago the stillness of a Judean night was shattered by a baby's cry. Born in poverty, raised in obscurity, the Child of Mary would become the most controversial Person in history. . . .¹

He Himself challenged His generation—and every subsequent one—with the question. "Who do you say I am?" He asked His disciples. And when Peter replied spontaneously, "You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God," Jesus acknowledged the answer with "Simon son of Jonah, you are favoured indeed! You did not learn that from mortal man; it was revealed to you by my heavenly Father" (Matt. 16:15-17, NEB).²

Seventh-day Adventists have faced the issue of the ages—Who was Jesus?—and have given Peter's answer. They believe that Jesus of Nazareth was no mere man—although He was fully human. They believe that He was Immanuel, God with us; that the eternal God had condescended to be incarnated among humanity in Him. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God." "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth; we have beheld his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father" (John 1:1, 14, RSV).³

How God could become man is a mystery. Human experience offers no analogy that remotely unlocks the wonder of it all. "Without controversy great is the mystery of godliness: God was manifest in the flesh" (1 Tim. 3:16).

Seventh-day Adventists do not attempt to unlock the mystery of the Incarnation. We accept the testimony of Scripture, rejoicing in the good news that God has not left us alone, that He gave His Son, eternally preexistent, to us in the miracle of Bethlehem. And we accept Him as God in the flesh because of what we have experienced and still experience: in His name we find forgiveness of sins, freedom from guilt, and joyous fellowship for a new way of life. . . .

That is why we're a people who love and follow Jesus. He is the center of our faith. More than any doctrine, more than any practice, more than any facet of organization, more than any goal or purpose—our movement focuses on Him. Without Him everything else we believe in and preach; all our hospitals, schools, and universities; all our evangelistic crusades and social uplift programs—everything would be worthless. He is the "bottom line" of Adventism.

Christianity, as we understand it, is essentially a relationship. It is a day-by-day experience of knowing Jesus, the risen Lord, of sensing His guiding hand and powerful presence. It is like a marriage: we have fallen in love with Him, and each day we seek to love Him more and know Him better. . . .

JESUS—OUR FAVORITE SUBJECT

The life and teachings of Jesus—it is our favorite subject for reflection. Probably the most popular spiritual book outside the Bible that Adventists study is *The Desire of Ages*, by Ellen G. White. A massive devotional study of Jesus, it urges us to spend time every day in contemplation of the miracle of the Incarnation.

"It would be well for us to spend a thoughtful hour each day in contemplation of the life of Christ. We should take it point by point, and let the imagination grasp each scene, especially the closing ones. As we thus dwell upon His great sacrifice for us, our confidence in Him will be more constant, our love will be quickened, and we shall be more deeply imbued with His spirit. If we would be saved at last, we must learn the lesson of penitence and humiliation at the foot of the cross."⁴

Especially the closing scenes! Great as was the life of Jesus—His teachings, His miracles, His sinless accomplishment of the Father's mission—its high point came at the end. Unlike any other person, this Man was born to die. . . .

JESUS DIED FOR THE SINS OF THE WORLD

We're people who believe what the Bible teaches about the cross—that Jesus died for the sins of the world. We believe that "he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed." "God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them" (Isa. 53:5, KJV; 2 Cor. 5:19, KJV).

Jesus lived a perfect life as a man. But without the cross we are lost—His perfect example only condemns us, showing us what we *might* be and *should* be. The guilt of our failures lies heavy on us; we have nothing to boast of before God, nothing to give us hope.

But His cross gives us hope. . . . We believe. We accept that in Jesus God has done for us what we

In Him we find pleasures evermore; in Him we have peace, joy, and strength for each day; in Him we have hope for a glorious tomorrow.

could never do for ourselves, that He has taken our place, borne our penalty, and given us life.

So nothing can take away the centrality of Calvary for us. We understand from Scripture that Jesus is now our heavenly high priest, that He is judge. But these beliefs do not add to the value of the sacrifice He made for us on the cross; rather they flow from it. The cross is the turning point of history. . . .

"Christ was treated as we deserve, that we might be treated as He deserves. He was condemned for our sins, in which He had no share, that we might be justified by His righteousness, in which we had no share. He suffered the death which was ours, that we might receive the life which was His. 'With his stripes we are healed.'"¹ . . .

TWO-PART NAME HAS MEANING

The two parts of our name, "seventh day" and "Adventist," express how we love and try to follow Jesus.

"Seventh day" lets people know that we observe the Sabbath, the seventh day of the week—Saturday—as a day of worship. The Sabbath was the day Jesus observed, and therefore we too observe it. Although Jesus came into conflict with the religious leaders of His day over the manner of Sabbathkeeping, He never suggested that the day itself should be changed. We try to keep the Sabbath as Jesus taught us to keep it. It is a beautiful day, a time of relaxation, fellowship, worship, and helping others. To us it symbolizes our rest and freedom in Him—the One who has given us rest from sin and made us free for Himself. . . .

The Sabbath, of course, is but one of the Ten Commandments. The Scriptures take this law seriously, and so do we. By God's grace we try to live according to its ideals, especially as Jesus expounded them in the Sermon on the Mount and by His own example. Now, we don't do so in order to win God's love or to be saved. Instead, because He loves us and has forgiven us by Jesus' death for us, we want to show our love by a life

that is like His. We are His sons and daughters, and we want to honor Him by living worthy of His name. He said: "If you love me, you will keep my commandments" (John 14:15, RSV).

"Adventist" expresses our belief that the Jesus whom we love is coming again. "I go to prepare a place for you. And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again," He promised (verses 2, 3, KJV). "This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven," the angels assured at His ascension (Acts 1:11, RSV).

We rejoice at that prospect. We know it is sure—His first coming guarantees it; Calvary has made absolutely certain His eventual reign as King of kings and Lord of lords.

From our understanding of the Bible, we believe His return is near. So we proclaim it around the world by voice and pen, by radio and television, from pulpits and in homes. We want people to know about it, to be ready for it, to rejoice with us in it. In this world men and women are driven by various motivations. Some people live for pleasure, some for power, and some for possessions. And many in our times are adrift, with no guiding star.

Jesus is the guiding star for Seventh-day Adventists. In Him we find pleasures evermore; in Him we have peace, joy, and strength for each day; in Him we have hope for a glorious tomorrow.

That's why we're people who love and follow Jesus. ♣

¹ William G. Johnsson, "Our Guiding Star: Faith in Jesus, the Incarnate God, Is the Path of Salvation," *Adventist Review*, Feb. 11, 1999, pp. 22-24.

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⁴ Ellen G. White, *The Desire of Ages* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1898, 1940), p. 83.

⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 25.

William G. Johnsson was a theologian, author, and the editor of *Adventist Review* from 1982 to 2006.

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THE ORPHAN, THE ANGEL, AND THE LONG WALK

*Adventist pioneer Dan Shireman—
builder extraordinary*

BERT HALOVIK

Dan Shireman was a survivor. His mother died when he was only 4. Three years later, in 1841, his father died in a train explosion, leaving Dan alone in the world.

So Dan learned about sleeping in barns, in the woods, on lumber piles. He wore his clothes “until they were in strings and rags.” He learned about rejection. People turned him away when they saw him “filled with vermin on his head and body.” They feared the contagious diseases he might be carrying. Dan made a vow: If ever he had his own home, he would never turn a needy person away.

Young Shireman became adept at many kinds of work as he struggled to survive. He learned carpentry and became a general mechanic and brick mason. In addition, he learned to walk great distances. When he was 16, he cared for the horses of a man who, in return, took him to northern Illinois. Dan eventually walked from there to Iowa, where he supported himself working at various trades.

Dan Shireman married Amelia McDowell in 1857. The next year, in Lisbon, Iowa, he heard Adventist preacher Josiah Hart present the Sabbath. Within 30 minutes Dan accepted the new light. Soon he and Amelia became Sabbathkeeping Adventists and began their lifelong ministry.¹

They first tried to establish an Adventist presence in West Union, Iowa, where Amelia’s parents lived. Because of his deep poverty, Dan walked 130 miles to get there. The attempt to convince Amelia’s parents failed. Yet the Shiremans succeeded in introducing Adventism to Mary Jane Daniells, mother of a future president of the General Conference.

Shireman’s “longest walk” came in 1860. His longing for fellowship with believers was so strong that he walked from West Union to the conference meeting at Marion, Iowa, a round-trip of 160 miles. Dan felt well repaid for his long walk, however, for he met James and Ellen White for the first time and rejoiced with them in the conviction of the near Advent.

Ellen White inspired the type of ministry begun by the Shiremans. Most Adventist ministers of the time centered their evangelism on debates. Dan Shireman, however, became a forerunner of the caring pastoral ministry. He responded to Ellen White's call for families to enter areas that had no Adventists. In such places the gospel message would flourish because of Sabbath-keepers who moved in and lived humble lives that witnessed to their neighbors.

The Shiremans thus began a ministry that resulted in their building more than 45 homes, in as many different locations. They left brand-new Adventist communities in every place they lived.

MESSAGE FROM AN ANGEL

Dan's ministry was affirmed dramatically in 1887. An "angel of the Lord" challenged the Shiremans to proclaim, the quickest way they could, "The Lord is coming."²

The angel also wrote a message to the Shiremans: "God will have all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth" (see 1 Tim. 2:4). After signing the message "Christ's Expositor," the messenger suddenly disappeared. That experience and textual focus guided the Shiremans for the remainder of their lives. The all-inclusiveness of the gospel message became more and more meaningful to them.

Dan and Amelia Shireman began a new ministry in the mountains of North Carolina in 1890 with an urgent sense of mission. As he traveled the mountains, Dan recalled crossing that same Appalachian chain some 40 years earlier. He remembered his poverty, lack of education, isolation, and fears. From Dutch Creek the couple walked together the nine miles to Mast. There they began meetings, hoping to convince some about the truths of the everlasting gospel.

Dan Shireman quickly became part of the mountain community. His humble past and genuine love of people endeared him to the mountaineers. His humanitarian, nonsectarian concerns made him welcome in many a community and church congregation.



Ellen White, along with Daniel Shireman, and others attending a convention in Nashville, Tennessee, ride in a horse-drawn wagon, March 1901.

Elder Shireman built more than Seventh-day Adventist churches in the mountains of North Carolina. As he witnessed the needs of these communities, he began to build small schools. The first was at Hildebran, where Dan initially held tent meetings and established an Adventist community. That school included a teachers' home, students' home, farm and farmhouse, blacksmith shop, and chapel. The *Hickory Mercury* newspaper praised the results, applauding the Adventist pastor for "the vast amount of good one live, energetic, persevering Christian man can do in a neighborhood." Other communities asked Dan to establish similar enterprises.

Shireman displayed remarkable energy. His workday began at 2:00 a.m. and usually occupied 16-18 hours, even in his 70s. He often lacked adequate nourishment, sometimes subsisting on bread and water. This self-imposed poverty sprang from his commitment to the task.

After turning over operation of the Hildebran school complex to the North Carolina Conference, Dan responded to a request from the citizens of Toluca. Within 24 hours of the Shiremans' arrival, some 20 men with teams reported to work.

Another phase of Dan Shireman's remarkable ministry began in 1905, at age 71. He developed an enterprise that he had been preparing for all his life. The Shiremans had constantly made their home a boarding place for the needy. Now Dan built a home in Toluca that he designed as a live-in family school for orphans.

During this time Amelia died a painful death from stomach cancer, which had caused her agony for a decade. Dan wrote Ellen White that Amelia had urged him to continue the work he was doing for the orphans at Toluca.

As the widower reflected on the now-broken family ministry, he remembered Amelia's tender sympathy toward the poor and how her willingness to share their troubles had endeared her to others. He reminisced about his six children, all of whom had died in their youth and were buried in five different locations. With his wife and six

“Every man is not dependent upon a school or college education to do work for the Master, if he is converted to God, soul, body, and spirit.”

children dead, Dan felt “like a lone tree in a field with all the trees in the forest cut down.”

Soon Dan had a building with 16 rooms that served as an orphanage. He also had a school building with a home for teachers. The community donated 30,000 feet of lumber, and Dan sold his home at Hildebran to provide funds to support the orphans and teachers.

The Toluca school and orphanage provided a family setting for 15 to 20 orphans. Besides a “father” and “mother” for the children, the group consisted of a principal and his wife, a cook, a seamstress, a farm superintendent, and a teacher. Dan served as “general overseer.” The children of the family worked on the farm and in the various industries. Besides school and work, they participated in morning and evening worship services.

While in his 70s, Dan Shireman established enterprises similar to Toluca in several other locations in the North Carolina mountains.

CORRESPONDENCE MINISTRY

After some near-fatal accidents and debilitating injuries, Elder Shireman reluctantly retired. Counsel from both Ellen White and the General Conference Committee convinced him. At age 77 he resigned himself to the more “sedate” life of a corresponding ministry.

Dan had remarried a few years earlier. He and his wife opened their home to a disabled writer and her homeless mother. Together the group wrote letters to those they could interest in the gospel. Since 2:00 a.m. had been Dan’s “getting-up time for years,” he could still fill his day spreading the gospel. He wrote to Mrs. White, “I expect to spend my closing days in His service.” He could not be idle, he told her. He and his wife visited neighbors, distributed SDA literature, held evening meetings, and told “the simple story of salvation.”

Ellen White often praised the kind of ministry fostered by the Shiremans. She considered that Dan had done “a noble work to advance the truth.” His efforts had been “in accordance with the will of the Lord.” She urged, “Many more should work as Brother Shireman has been working.”³

Mrs. White understood Dan Shireman’s sense of inferiority over his lack of formal education. She told the delegates to the 1901 General Conference session that he received his education as did John the Baptist in the wilderness. She praised his ministry of establishing “church after church” through his work as a carpenter and builder. She told the congregation, “Every man is not dependent upon a school or college education to do work for the Master, if he is converted to God, soul, body, and spirit.”⁴

Ellen White applied the Shireman experience to the variety of ministries possible within the church. While some may not preach, “they can help in many other ways.” Said she, “God has given us Brother Shireman’s work as an object lesson.” She added, “There are others who can and should work as he has worked.”⁵ Because of Dan Shireman’s “unpretentious” manner in presenting the gospel, he reached “a class that ministers generally cannot touch,” she concluded.⁶

Elder Shireman wrote one of his last articles for the *Review* in 1914. It recalled what the angel told him 27 years earlier: “We should live as if we believe with our whole hearts that the Lord is soon coming.”

Dan never forgot his origins. He wondered “why the Lord gave me the truth so early when there were so many educated and well-to-do persons who have never received it.” He came to this conclusion: “The humblest child of God can be instrumental in the salvation of many souls.”

Dan Shireman died January 26, 1920, at the age of 85. He rests beside Amelia in the cemetery at Hildebran, North Carolina. 📌

¹ While Mrs. Amelia Shireman participated fully in the family’s ministry, her story is not told here, since it would require a separate article.

² The full experience appears in a document in the General Conference Archives and is affirmed in a letter from Ellen White to Brother and Sister Shireman, Apr. 17, 1902 (letter 61, 1902).

³ Ellen G. White manuscript 16, 1902.

⁴ Ellen G. White, in *General Conference Bulletin*, Apr. 8, 1901, p. 127.

⁵ Ellen G. White manuscript 37, 1901.

⁶ Ellen G. White to Edson White, Aug. 8, 1902.

When this was written, **Bert Haloviak** served as assistant director of Archives and Statistics at the General Conference. He passed away October 18, 2022. This article appeared in the *Adventist Review*, May 31, 1990.



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LIFE AND LOVE

God is all about it.

It was an early morning, but not the kind I enjoy. My favorite early mornings I'm propped in bed, watching the sun come up, color spreading across the sky; talking with God or with my husband, Greg. Those are the relaxed, intimate mornings, where life is savored and moments matter.

Today was different. The alarm rang at 3:15 a.m., and I groaned. Greg was already headed for the shower while I stumbled about in the dark, irritated at the lack of sleep and the rush for the airport. These are the harried days, the dash to push everything into the suitcase, the rush on the freeway, then the agonized wait to drop off a bag or get through security. Today we arrived at the gate with time to spare.

I sat down and stared out the window, but it was still too dark to see anything. *Might as well be useful, Jill.* Digging in my carry-on, I pulled out my laptop. Work never stopped; here was as good as anywhere to wade back in. A half hour later the airport noise had faded into the background when suddenly the voice of the Southwest agent registered. "A1-30, please line up on this side." Greg and I took our place in line, while I juggled papers and my laptop, hardly noticing the older gentleman who came behind me. But I heard a woman's voice that made me turn. "Here's your ticket; you're A24." *Why would you tell an adult his number in line?*

She was pretty, with short hair and an arm flung around his shoulders. "Just stand here, and follow this line of people."

He shook his head. "I've flown plenty; I know how to do this."

She smiled, "I know, Dad. Here's your backpack; let's put it on you." Suddenly she was crying, holding him tightly, as if she were the parent and he the child. "You'll be OK," she said. "Call me later." And then she walked off, back toward security. I hadn't seen someone past security without a ticket since September 11. It was clear she had been given special exemption because of her father's memory issues.

He straightened and started to talk with us. A few times he asked, "Where am I going now?" but he managed to get on the plane, just one row ahead of us. I wondered about his story, their father-daughter bond, and what had led to this place.

Later we landed in St. Louis and stepped outside the terminal where I saw a young girl, about 10, spot her father. She dropped her suitcase and ran toward him. He caught her in his arms as she cried, "Daddy!" and I had to look away. It was too much to intrude. This was their daddy-daughter moment.

Today I'm reminded of the fleeting nature of relationships: here today, drastically altered tomorrow. Life is not about the hustle of deadlines and accomplishments. It's about the people we meet and those who mean the most. It's about taking those moments and breathing it in.

For our God, the author of life, is all about love. 📌

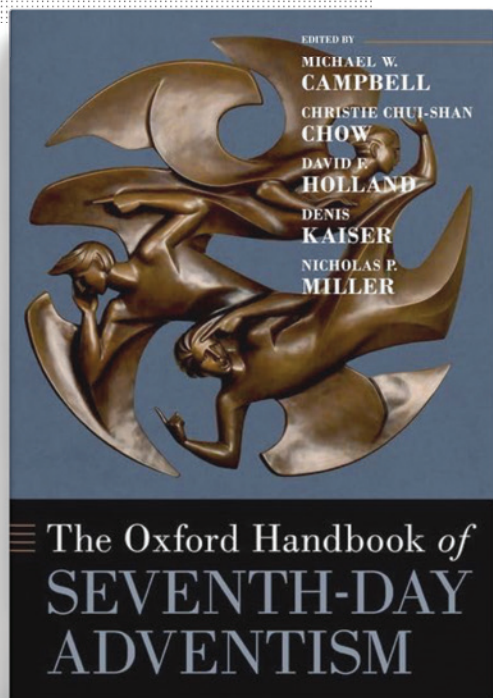
Jill Morikone is vice president and chief operations officer for Three Angels Broadcasting Network (3ABN), a supporting Adventist television network. She and her husband, Greg, live in southern Illinois and enjoy ministering together for Jesus.

JOURNEYS
WITH JESUS
JILL
MORIKONE



LIFE IS NOT ABOUT
THE HUSTLE OF
DEADLINES AND
ACCOMPLISHMENTS.

EDITORS' PICKS



The Oxford Handbook of Seventh-day Adventism

Michael W. Campbell, Christie Chui-Shan Chow, David F. Holland, Denis Kaiser, Nicholas P. Miller, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Seventh-Day Adventism* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2024), 605 pages, \$178. Reviewed by Nikolaus Satelmajer, D.Min., STM, former editor, *Ministry*, International Journal for Pastors.

This rather large book is an extraordinary undertaking. Its goal is to present Seventh-day Adventism to its readers, many of whom most likely will not be Seventh-day Adventist. Oxford University Press is a well-known publisher whose audience is worldwide and not confined to any particular group. The editorial team and writers must be commended for undertaking such a bold project.

The publisher states, “Broad and comprehensive in scope, each chapter addresses the history, theology, and social aspects of Adventism, and maps the development of its most influential manifestations” (book jacket). Is the goal achieved? Readers who are not Adventists or are not familiar with Adventism will find the book helpful. Adventist readers, I believe, will find the book interesting and helpful, but they need to remember that they are not the only audience.

The fact that the writers represent many parts of the world and that their backgrounds vary makes the book a more useful tool. Several of the writers are not Seventh-day Adventist. Yet their contributions show that they have a deep understanding, and even appreciation, of Seventh-day Adventism.

The book covers a broad range of topics. While it is not practical to list the titles of the 38 chapters, a list of the sections will help the reader appreciate the scope of the book. The sections are: History of Adventism; Scripture, Inspiration, and Ellen G. White; Theology; Worship, Preaching, and Ordinances; Organization and Ministry; Global Church; Culture, Ethics, and Politics.

Before discussing how the book may be of value to individuals and congregations, I want to point out two areas that would, I believe, strengthen a future edition. First, some of the chapters would be strengthened and more helpful if they had been reviewed by additional readers. Second, some of the chapters do not adequately recognize that the Adventist Church is a worldwide movement.

The individual reader will, I believe, find the book very helpful in either reading for the first time about Sev-

enth-day Adventism or adding to a personal knowledge of the church. Though I have read or studied most of the topics in the book, I found it helpful to get additional information and understanding. The book is not a defense of Adventism, but rather an explanation of the movement. I test the value of a book when I come to the last page. Am I glad I am on the last page, or do I wish the book would not end? As large as this book is, I wish it had continued.

In addition to personal reading, there is another, perhaps even more beneficial, way to use the book. Church groups will find it a helpful source for study and discussion. A significant number of churches have “small groups,” and this book would be a wonderful resource for such groups. The

“In our politically obsessed age, the Adventist insight that some things matter more than politics and that most of the time there are things more worthy of our attention is daringly countercultural.”

topics covered are not of interest only to Seventh-day Adventists; thus churches should consider inviting those who are not members to such study groups. While most of the chapters will confirm our beliefs and practices, some will also introduce new themes.

All of the chapters would be a good base for discussion by Adventists. For those who are not Adventist, the following chapters would, I believe, be of significant interest:

Eschatology, Great Controversy, and Prophetic Interpretation (p. 127)

Creation (p. 199)

Adventist Lifestyle (p. 228)

Health Care and Medical Work (p. 305)

Adventist Education (p. 323)

Adventists and Archaeology (p. 337)

Youth and Family Ministry (p. 352)

Epilogue: Adventism in the Larger Protestant World (p. 573)

There is one important theme that is not addressed in the book. At their start, most religious reformation movements, in spite of the challenges they face, exhibit a high level of energy and focus. These movements go through various stages, and all too many seem to lose the enthusiasm and focus of their origin. They tend to concentrate on internal operational matters, and arguments flourish. The founders of these movements would hardly recognize the movement as it is now. Are Seventh-day Adventists facing this challenge? Readers of the book and discussion groups using it need to address these questions.

The book ends with a challenging and hopeful observation. Alec Ryrie, a professor at Durham University, writes, “In our politically obsessed age, the Adventist insight that some things matter more than politics and that most of the time there are things more worthy of our attention is daringly countercultural” (p. 381).

I pray he is right. ▀

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HIGH-STAKES INFLUENCE:

Parents, Teens, and Marijuana

Q: My 45-year-old ex-husband uses marijuana recreationally. I caught our almost 18-year-old daughter trying it. Her dad claims it is legal and she should choose for herself. She loves her dad and is strongly influenced by him. Is he correct? Isn't smoking marijuana risky?

A: You're right to be concerned about your daughter using marijuana, and we empathize with you. In your case, the risks may not be only health-related. Depending on your home state, recreational marijuana might be legal for adults, but in nearly all jurisdictions it's illegal for minors, including "almost 18s." Furthermore, encouraging or enabling a minor to use marijuana could have serious legal consequences for the adults involved, including potential criminal charges. Protecting your daughter is of high priority, so we strongly advise taking immediate steps to address this situation with tact but ensuring that she understands that this is serious. We realize that coparenting is complex and delicate, but in some way encourage your ex-husband to get the facts since he has the greater health risk and may also have legal liability.

Although a 2017 report showed that 6.5 percent of adolescents aged 12 to 17 were current marijuana users,¹ it does not make its use by minors legal or harmless. With increasing legalization, there seems to be a lack of appreciation for marijuana risks. Teens especially don't think of marijuana as a dangerous drug, and to some people, legalization gives the "appearance of being safe." Marijuana use can interfere with the final stages of your daughter's brain development, potentially leading to long-term cognitive impairment, issues with memory, attention, and decision-making. This may negatively affect her academically and even socially.

Also, adolescents and young adults who use marijuana are at a higher risk of fatal car accidents² and of developing mental health disorders, including schizophrenia. A Swedish study published in

1987 found that people who used marijuana more than 50 times by the age of 18 were three times more likely than others to have schizophrenia at age 45.³ Regardless of the state in which you live, marijuana use by a minor is most likely illegal, and that could lead to criminal charges and a permanent record.

Your ex-husband faces several potential risks from marijuana use too. It can elevate his blood pressure and heart rate, which could exacerbate any existing cardiovascular issues and can make him more prone to heart attack. Chronic use can lead to cognitive decline, memory impairment, slower mental processing speeds, anxiety, depression, and paranoia.

We strongly suggest you urgently have an open and honest conversation with your daughter about the risks of using marijuana. Focus on the potential impact on her brain development, mental health, daily risks, and future opportunities. Express your concerns out of love and care, sharing verifiable facts and research. Her earthly father may not be aware or maybe he doesn't care, but her heavenly Father certainly knows, and HE definitely cares!

For more on medical marijuana and Seventh-day Adventists, please visit the Health Ministries website: <https://www.healthministries.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/medical-marijuana-considerations-for-seventh-day-adventists.pdf>. 📄

¹ Retrieved from <https://store.samhsa.gov/product/results-2017-national-survey-drug-use-and-health-nsduh-key-substance-use-and-mental-health>.

² Retrieved from https://www.drugpolicyfacts.org/chapter/cannabis_marijuana.

³ Sven Andréasson, Ann Engström, Peter Allebeck, Ulf Rydberg, "Cannabis and Schizophrenia: A Longitudinal Study of Swedish Conscripts," *The Lancet*, Dec. 26, 1987, [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736\(87\)92620-1](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(87)92620-1).

Peter N. Landless, a board-certified nuclear cardiologist, is director of Adventist Health Ministries at the General Conference. **Zeno L. Charles-Marcel**, a board-certified internist, is an associate director of Adventist Health Ministries at the General Conference.

WHEN GOD PLANS

We need only say yes!

Incredulous happenings mark the ministry of Jesus, highlighted by more than 30 miracles. As disciples of Jesus, some of us have experienced events worthy of headlines. Most of us, however, lead ordinary lives—nothing spectacular, just days filled with trivial events steered by our choices and bookended by waking up and falling asleep. Yet even the ordinary is divinely orchestrated when the heart is open to God’s calling.

James was an information technology student in Kenya who, on a whim, applied to an advertisement for a digital evangelist that had randomly popped up on his

screen. Months later he received an email leading to volunteer service at Adventist World Radio’s Center for Digital Evangelism (AWR CDE) in the Philippines. A year into his service James felt called to change careers and become a pastor, but this was financially impossible.

After hearing James’s testimony at a Friday vespers program and getting to know him, Pastor Robert Caderma, president of the Southern Asia-Pacific Division, felt impressed to arrange for a scholarship for James at Mountain View College. Today James is studying to be a pastor. His story exemplifies what happens when people, organizations, and plans align with God’s plan, when decisions are made within the context of missions. For James, these elements were in play:

Information: Whether someone actively searches for a place to serve or algorithms direct assignments to someone such as James, online platforms such as VividFaith offer mission-focused service opportunities in the Adventist Church.

Opportunity: Increasingly, individuals from the global south are becoming missionaries in other countries as organizations become more open to diversity. AWR CDE volunteers, for instance, represent more than 20 nationalities.

Integration: The church is adopting a more global mission perspective. Whereas the scholarship James received would typically have gone to someone local to the division, Pastor Caderma states, “I decided to support James because his unwavering commitment to spread the gospel and serve others aligns with the mission of the church. His impactful work and dedication to community outreach demonstrate his potential as a future leader.”

The Adventist Church is a movement of people who are saying yes to missions! As of the writing of this article, 16,203 have registered in VividFaith to continue in the footsteps of J. N. Andrews and others. But they need places to go, projects that need their service, and there aren’t enough openings! It is time to create more mission opportunities and watch God at work. Whether through technology or people, be it happenstance or deliberate, when the response is yes to God’s call, missions unfold in amazing ways.

As Ellen White writes: “Let every worker in the Master’s vineyard study, plan, devise methods, to reach the people where they are. We must do something out of the common course of things. We must arrest the attention.”**

* Ellen G. White, *Evangelism* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1946), pp. 122, 123.

Fylvia Fowler Kline is manager of VividFaith.com, the Seventh-day Adventist Church’s online platform for finding and recruiting missionaries.

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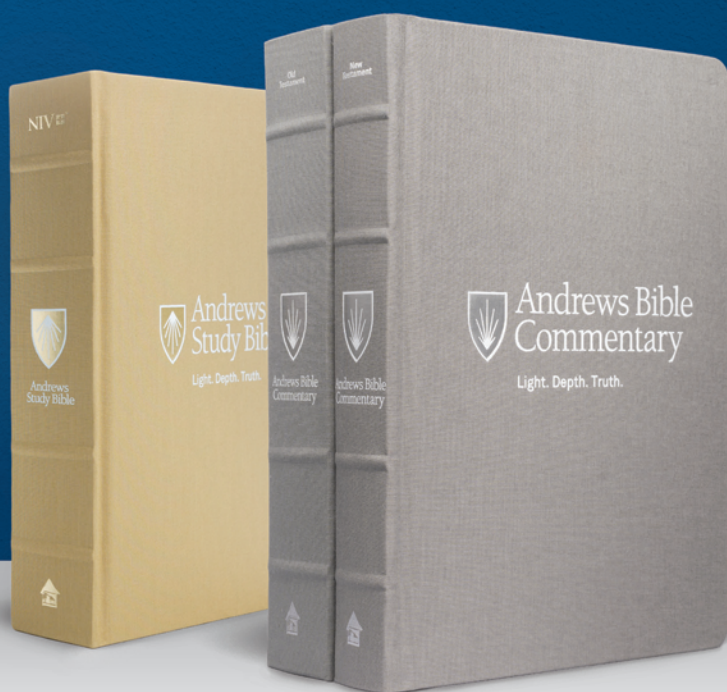
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